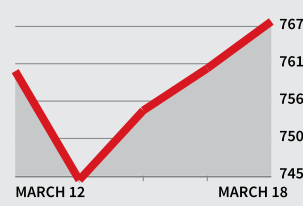


the hindu businessline

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IN FOCUS

	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	23777.80	+196.65
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	21.06	+0.18
US Dollar (in ₹)	92.63	+0.26
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	154259.00	-786
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	249907.00	-2433

FISCAL WATCH.

Advance tax mop up 6% in FY26 despite non-corporate dip; target likely to be hit as W. Asia crises escalate **p12**



TECHNOPHILE.

Galaxy S26 Ultra stands out as the best Android flagship with refined, powerful performance **p4**

Govt mandates 60% seats on flights to be free of selection fee

PROFIT STRAIN. Airlines uneasy on rising costs; ancillary revenues account for 10-15% of income

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

In a passenger-centric move, the Centre has directed airlines to ensure that a minimum of 60 per cent of seats on flights are made available without any additional charge (seat selection fee), while also requiring carriers to seat passengers travelling on the same PNR together, preferably in adjacent seats.

As part of a broader push to improve transparency and standardisation, the Ministry of Civil Aviation, through the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA), mandated airlines to clearly articulate policies on carriage of sports equip-



COST LAYERS. It is a significant move as airlines price travel components separately under unbundled services framework

ment, musical instruments and pets. Besides, the directions mandate airlines to prominently display passenger rights across platforms and ensure communication of entitlements in regional languages.

BUNDLED FRAMEWORK The move assumes significance given the current unbundled services framework, in which airlines price various components of travel separately.

At present, most seat selections are chargeable, with passengers often paying extra for preferred seats or to ensure adjacent seating even when travelling on a single booking.

Ancillary revenues, including seat selection, baggage and onboard services

like food and beverages, account for 10-15 per cent of airline revenues, with seat selection contributing a relatively smaller share within this segment.

RISE IN COST OF OPS

There is unease in the industry over the new norms, especially given the high cost of operations.

“Given the crude oil price situation, it is very difficult for airlines to survive if the government continues to enforce policies that are financially unviable for the sector,” a senior executive of a leading low-cost carrier told *businessline*.

A senior executive of another airline said that the impact on fares may be limited as seat selection charges themselves typically start at

around ₹200 and form a small portion of overall ancillary revenues.

Globally, such practices are uncommon, with most aviation markets allowing airlines the flexibility to price services under deregulated frameworks.

According to Mark Martin, Founder and CEO of Martin Consulting, “Selection of seats is considered a value-plus offering and preference. Although the 60 per cent limit will continue to allow airlines to sell window and aisle seats as a ‘value-plus add-on’, the bigger impact I see is with the Premium Economy product, as the middle seat in Premium Economy will need to be classified as a nil-value seat.”

According to Kinjal Shah, Senior Vice-President and Co-Group Head, Corporate Sector Ratings, ICRA, the DGCA directive will not have any material impact on the revenues of the airlines.

“Ancillary revenues have accounted for less than 10 per cent of the revenues of India’s airlines over the last few years. Ancillary revenues comprise seat selection charges, extra baggage charges and food sales, among others,” she said.

Oil, gas spike after Iran warns of retaliatory attacks

Bloomberg

Oil and European natural gas prices surged as Iran listed energy assets in the region that it would target in response to a US and Israeli attack on its upstream industry.

Brent oil climbed 6.1 per cent to a high of \$109.75 a barrel, while Europe’s gas benchmark jumped 9.1 per cent, according to data from ICE Futures Europe. Iran said that the US and Israel attacked the South Pars gas field at Asaluyeh. The assets are important for domestic supply and also shipments to Iraq and Turkey. Tehran issued a list of similar assets in Saudi Arabia, Qatar and the UAE that it said residents should avoid.

[Read more on p3](#)

Indian Bank plans to raise ₹5,000 cr via infra bonds

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai

Indian Bank plans to raise around ₹5,000 crore by way of infrastructure bonds by this month-end, with the public sector lender also securing the board approval for this fundraise on Wednesday.

[Also read p5](#)

Ministries’ blame game over CAFE-2 dues stalls rollout of new fuel norms

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

A high-level meeting in the Prime Minister’s Office (PMO) on Monday laid bare the bureaucratic drift that has stalled enforcement of Corporate Average Fuel Efficiency (CAFE-2) norms, with officials from multiple ministries trading blame over more than ₹8,000 crore in penalties yet to be recovered from non-compliant carmakers.

According to sources, representatives from the Ministries of Power, Road Transport and Highways, Heavy Industries and Petroleum and Natural Gas failed to establish a clear accountability framework during the hour-long meeting. The immediate trigger was a pointed query from Principal Secretary-2 to the Prime Minister, Shaktikanta Das, on who imposes the penalties, who approves them and, crucially, who is responsible for their recovery?

ACCOUNTABILITY GAP

“There was a lack of clarity regarding the implementation of CAFE-2, where overlapping mandates have resulted in enforcement falling through the cracks,” a source told *businessline*. The Bureau of Energy Efficiency (BEE), under the Power Ministry,



TO BE COLLECTED. Around ₹8,800 crore in penalties have been levied on 10 automakers for missing CAFE-2 targets

which is responsible for setting and notifying CAFE norms and imposing penalties, reportedly indicated that recovery of penalties did not lie within its remit. The Road Ministry is said to have pushed back, arguing that its jurisdiction is limited to enforcement of the Motor Vehicles Act and does not extend to fuel efficiency compliance penalties. “The Ministry openly said that CAFE norms were initiated by BEE/Power Ministry; so it should be responsible for the recoveries,” a source said.

The deadlock assumes significance as the government prepares to roll out CAFE-3 from April 1, 2027. The PMO reportedly made it clear that unless the confusion over institutional responsibilities is resolved, CAFE-3 norms cannot move forward.

PENALTY GRIDLOCK

Data presented at the meeting underscored the scale of

the issue. Around ₹8,800 crore in penalties have been levied on 10 major automakers for failing to meet the CAFE-2 targets up to FY23.

Hyundai Motor India faces the stiffest fine at over ₹2,800 crore, followed by Mahindra & Mahindra (₹1,788 crore) and Kia India (₹1,346 crore). These amounts remain tied up in disputes between companies and the BEE.

At the same time, Maruti Suzuki India, Tata Motors, Toyota Kirloskar Motor and JSW MG Motor India and luxury carmakers such as Mercedes-Benz India, BMW Group India and Volvo India have complied with the prescribed norms.

Sources said Shaktikanta Das directed the ministries to come back with a consensus mechanism on enforcement and recovery before any further deliberations on CAFE-3.

No date has been fixed for the next meeting.

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SCAN TO KNOW MORE

Gold jewellery sale seen rising 40% during Gudi Padwa, Ugadi

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

Jewellers are expecting a 40 per cent rise in gold jewellery demand during the Marathi

new year *Gudi Padwa*, and Telugu and Kannada new year *Ugadi*, which fall on Thursday.

The industry anticipates the recent fall in gold prices

to boost demand for lightweight jewellery, in particular. Gold prices fell by ₹789 to ₹1,54,879 per 10 g on Wednesday against ₹1,55,668 on Tuesday. Gold has crashed by

₹12,592 from ₹1,67,471 since March 2.

Similarly, silver slumped by ₹2,433 on Wednesday to ₹2,49,907 a kg against ₹2,52,340 on Tuesday. Silver

prices have declined by ₹39,941 per kg since the start of this month.

Rajesh Rokde, Chairman, Gem and Jewellery Council, said despite elevated gold

prices, jewellers are optimistic that *Gudi Padwa* and *Ugadi* will see strong consumer sentiment due to deep cultural significance.

While volatility in the international markets may keep prices firm in the near term, the industry expects demand to remain resilient, with consumers increasingly opting for lighter jewellery pieces and innovative designs.

[Report on p10](#)

AM/NS ₹70,000 cr AP steel plant will boost national growth, says CEO

G Naga Sridhar
Hyderabad

The greenfield integrated steel plant being set up in Andhra Pradesh by ArcelorMittal and Nippon Steel (AM/NS) will be a catalyst for growth not only for the State but also for the country, Dilip Oommen, Chief Executive Officer, AM/NS India, said.

A steel plant generally attracts a cluster of ancillary industries, contributing to the development of the industrial and social ecosystem, Oommen told *businessline* on Tuesday.

The foundation stone for

the plant will be laid on March 23 at Rajayyapeta in Anakapalli district, marking one of the largest greenfield industrial investments in AP.

AM/NS India will invest over ₹70,000 crore in the plant, he said, adding, “We will be well-positioned to leverage the best technologies from ArcelorMittal and Nippon Steel.”

The investment will be shared by both entities.

JOB OPPORTUNITIES

The plant, with a capacity of 8.2 million tonnes per annum in the first phase, will be one of India’s most advanced steel-making facilities.

The project is expected to generate around one lakh direct and indirect jobs.

[Read more on p2](#)

QUICKLY.

BlackSoil Capital raises ₹200 cr for climate lending



Bengaluru: Mumbai-based alternate credit platform BlackSoil Capital raised ₹200 crore in debt funding from Impact Fund Denmark to expand climate-focused and inclusive lending in India. It will support climate adaptation and mitigation and expand access to credit for low-income and underserved segments, including MSMEs, financial institutions and emerging corporations. A major portion of the capital will be deployed in tier-2 and tier-3 markets. It will focus on women-led businesses and sectors with limited access to formal finance with increased exposure to renewable energy, climate-smart agriculture, sustainable supply chains, circular economy models and inclusive finance. Impact Fund Denmark invests in emerging markets to support development outcomes aligned with global sustainability goals. **OUR BUREAU**

AM/NS India’s ₹70,000 crore plant ‘to boost national growth’

FOCUS ON ANDHRA PRADESH. ‘Well-oiled’ govt a reason for locating project in State

G Naga Sridhar
Hyderabad

The upcoming greenfield integrated steel plant in Andhra Pradesh, being set up by ArcelorMittal and Nippon Steel India (AM/NS India), will be a catalyst for growth not only for the State but for the entire country, Dilip Oommen, Chief Executive Officer, AM/NS India, said. A steel plant generally attracts a cluster of ancillary industries, contributing to the development of the industrial and social ecosystem, Oommen told *businessline* on Wednesday. The foundation stone for the plant will be laid on March 23 at Rajayyapeta in Anakapalli district, marking one of the largest greenfield industrial investments in Andhra Pradesh. AM/NS India will invest over ₹70,000 crore in the plant, he said, adding, “We will be well-positioned to leverage the best technologies from both ArcelorMittal

The initial phase of the plant is expected to be commissioned in the first quarter of FY29

DILIP OOMMEN
Chief Executive Officer, AM/NS India



and Nippon Steel.” The investment will be shared by both entities. **1 LAKH JOBS** The plant, with a production capacity of 8.2 million tonnes per annum in the first phase, will be one of India’s most advanced steel-making facilities. The project is expected to generate around one lakh direct and indirect employment opportunities. On the location of the plant, the CEO said water-front availability, suitable infrastructure, access to raw materials and an investor-friendly State government

were key factors behind the decision to invest in Andhra Pradesh. Referring to the ease and speed of doing business, Oommen said: “To me, the Andhra Pradesh government is a well-oiled organisation, and the results are positive.” The land allotment was completed in just two months. The project had also received environmental clearance, and the company is in possession of 2,200 acres for the plant. The initial phase of the plant is expected to be commissioned in the first quarter of FY29, he said. At the na-

tional level, the project will support the objectives of the National Steel Policy, which aims to achieve 300 mtpa steel production capacity in the country by 2030-31, he said. At present, production is around 200 mtpa. It will be a win-win proposition for Andhra Pradesh’s *Swarna Andhra@2047* and *Atmanirbhar Viksit Bharat 2047*. Steel has been an integral part of the State’s development, and people are emotionally connected to Visakhapatnam as a steel hub. “The people of the State led the ‘Visakha Utku – Andhrula Hakku’ movement for the existing Vizag Steel Plant, and this new mega plant will further boost employment and regional development,” said Abhishikh Kishore, VC and MD, Andhra Pradesh Industrial Infrastructure Corporation (APIIC). The location of the upcoming plant will be about 70 km away from Visakhapatnam.

How poll-bound States woo women through cash transfers

Sourashis Banerjee
Chennai

With the Election Commission of India announcing Assembly poll schedules for Kerala, Assam, Tamil Nadu and West Bengal on March 16, commentators have started harping about how the welfare measures (especially women-specific ones) could influence voters. However, we want our readers to know just how much a qualifying woman or household from each of these States can “earn” per month from a possible combination of the direct benefit transfers (DBTs) in their States.

DATA FOCUS.

In West Bengal, under the Kanyashree Prakalpa (K-3), girls pursuing post-graduation in science and technology are given ₹2,500 per month while Lakshmir Bhandar gives ₹1,700 per month to women of the SC/ST communities. Given that Lakshmir Bhandar is a non-competing scheme, in the sense that all permanent residents of West Bengal aged 25-60 years and not a government employee or pensioner, can get the benefits irrespective of other DBT schemes and as there is no upper age-limit for availing of K-3, a woman aged above 25 pursuing a PG degree, from the SC/ST community, can receive ₹4,200 per month.

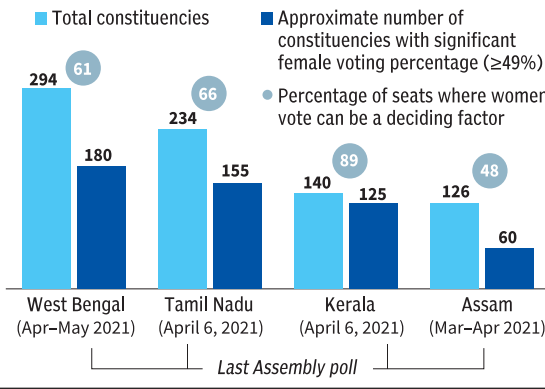
In Tamil Nadu, a household can net ₹2,000 monthly through the combination of Kalaigarn Magalir Urimai Thogai (KMUT) and Pudhumai Penn Thittam. However, qualifying conditions are stringent. Apart from several income related categories, the woman must be aged above 21 years and be recognised as the head of the family in the ration card to get the ₹1,000 DBT provided under KMUT. To get the other ₹1,000 under Pudhumai Penn Thittam, the claimant must have a girl or transgender child pursuing UG/ITI/Diploma/

Women-centric

Theoretical maximum monthly income from DBTs

State	Scheme	Payout per month (in ₹)	Conditions
West Bengal	Kanyashree Prakalpa K-3 + Lakshmir Bhandar	4,200	Women aged 25-60, belonging to SC/ST category, women in a PG programme in science/technology, ₹2,000 for other streams
Tamil Nadu	Kalaigarn Magalir Urimai Thogai + Pudhumai Penn Thittam	2,000	Women aged 21+, head of family, girl students in class VI-XII in Tamil medium school, other income conditions
Kerala	Social Security Pension	1,600	Widow or divorcee or unmarried woman (≥50 years), with annual income ≤ ₹1 lakh
Assam	Orunodoi Scheme + Mukhya Mantrir Nijut Moina Aasoni	3,750	Women aged 16-59, PG or B.Ed with 75% attendance, family income below ₹2 lakh and other income conditions

90% of seats in Kerala polled more women votes



Sources: Various State government portals, Budget documents, ECI

other courses recognised by the Tamil Nadu government and must have previously studied in a Tamil-medium institution from Class VI to Class XII. Kerala’s Social Security Pension schemes, which incidentally were also some of the earliest such schemes offered in the country, provide for a maximum of ₹1,600 per month. However, the qualifying conditions are quite dismal as women need to be either widows, divorcees or never-married by the age of 50 with their annual incomes below ₹1 lakh. In Assam, a potential ₹3,750 monthly payout via the Orunodoi Scheme and

Mukhya Mantrir Nijut Moina Aasoni is possible. However, this maximum is only receivable for 10 months in a year, and only to PG and BEd students, where ₹2,500 is paid under the Mukhya Mantrir Nijut Moina Aasoni, which can be supplemented by ₹1,250 per month from the Orunodoi Scheme by those who also qualify under the various income criteria of the Orunodoi Scheme. Data from the last Assembly elections show in Kerala approximately 89 per cent of constituencies have half of polled votes from women, followed by Tamil Nadu at 66 per cent, West Bengal at 61 per cent and Assam at 48 per cent.

Maruti to launch 7 SUVs, new small car

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Maruti Suzuki is gearing up to launch seven SUVs while ramping up production capacity to around 4 million units, as it focuses on SUVs for growth while reviving the entry-level segment with a new car described as “unique to Suzuki” for first-time buyers. The two-pronged strategy is aimed at regaining ground in the fast-growing utility vehicle market and boosting demand at the lower end, the company said in an investor presentation as part of a regulatory filing on March 17.

Maruti has been strengthening its SUV presence through models such as the Grand Vitara, Fronx and Jimny, helping lift its market share from 16.8 per cent in FY20 to 19.6 per cent in FY26 (April-February). “The share of SUVs within the Indian passenger vehicle market has been growing rapidly. Maruti Suzuki is expanding its product offerings in the SUV segment to secure market share,” Managing Director and CEO Hisashi Takeuchi said. He added that the company plans to introduce seven SUVs over the next five to six years. At the same time, the com-



pany is working to rebuild the entry-level segment, which has been under pressure in recent years. Follow-

ing GST-led price reductions of up to 10 per cent, the share of first-time buyers has risen from 41 per cent to 48 per cent, indicating early signs of recovery. **MULTI-FUEL STRATEGY** Maruti is also maintaining a multi-fuel strategy spanning CNG, hybrids and electric vehicles, reflecting its view that India’s energy mix requires a gradual transition rather than an immediate shift to EVs. Capacity expansion is being driven by new facilities such as the Kharkhoda plant and additional investments in Gujarat, aimed at supporting both domestic demand

and exports. The planned scale-up to 4 million units positions the company to capture a significant share of a market expected to grow to 5-6 million units by 2030. Sales trends reflect this shift. Maruti reported a total sales of 2.20 million units between April and February in FY26, up 7.6 per cent year-on-year, led by utility vehicles, even as the mini segment remains under pressure and sedans continue to decline. Exports have emerged as a key growth lever, rising 33.8 per cent to over 400,000 units, outpacing domestic growth and helping absorb incremental capacity.

Bosch, Tata Autocomp to set up 50:50 JV

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Bengaluru-headquartered Bosch Ltd said it will set up a 50:50 joint venture with the Pune-based Tata Autocomp Systems Ltd to manufacture e-axes and electric traction motors in India. The proposed entity is to be incorporated as a private limited company with an initial paid-up capital of ₹10 lakh and a total investment of up to ₹94 crore, as suppliers move to localise key electric vehicle drivetrain components. In a regulatory filing, Bosch said its board had approved entering into a joint venture (JV) agreement to set up the new entity that will undertake the “manufacture, sale, and after-sales service of e-axes and electric



traction motors and any other products”. **LOCALISATION IS KEY** The partnership combines Bosch’s engineering and software capabilities in electric drivetrains with Tata Autocomp’s manufacturing, sourcing, and localisation strengths, as well as its proximity to large domestic original equipment manufacturers, including within the Tata Group.

The JV will focus on manufacturing, sales, and after-sales service of electric powertrain components as automakers scale up electric vehicle launches across segments. **E-AXLE SYSTEMS** E-axes, which integrate the motor, inverter and transmission into a single unit, are key components of electric drivetrains and are increasingly being localised to reduce costs and improve supply chain resilience. They are emerging as a core component in EV architectures, helping simplify vehicle design and improve efficiency. The move comes at a time when automakers are accelerating electric vehicle launches, increasing demand for integrated electric powertrain systems.

Industry executives are of the view that localisation of such systems will be critical as automakers look to reduce costs and improve supply chain resilience, particularly in high-volume segments such as compact passenger vehicles and light commercial vehicles. **BOSCH INDIA REVENUES** Bosch, which reported India revenues of ₹18,087 crore in FY25, stated that the firm will contribute in engineering and development expertise, while Tata Autocomp will support operations, procurement and administration. Both companies will enter a segment that is seeing increasing competition, with players such as Sona Comstar, Dana and BorgWarner already building capabilities in electric drivetrains and e-axle systems.

Nazara Technologies to acquire Bluetile Games for \$100 million

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Nazara Technologies on Tuesday said it will acquire a controlling stake in European social gaming platform Bluetile Games and its affiliate BestPlay Systems for \$100.3 million (about ₹918 crore), as it looks to strengthen its presence in AI-driven gaming globally. The acquisition, to be executed through Nazara’s wholly-owned subsidiary Nazara Technologies UK, involves an initial purchase of a 50 per cent stake in both Bluetile and BestPlay. Nazara also holds a call option, and the sellers a corresponding put option, to ac-



Nitish Mittersain, CEO, Nazara Technologies
quire or sell the remaining 50 per cent stake by 2028 at a valuation based on 6.6x trailing calendar year EBITDA. Nazara said the transaction also includes performance-linked earn-outs of up to \$98.2 million, contingent on achieving revenue and profitability targets between

2027 and 2029 and payable annually from 2028 to 2030. **CASH FLOWS** A portion of the future payments may be funded through the acquired entities’ operating cash flows. Bluetile operates a portfolio of casual and social mobile games, including Yatzy, Domino Legends and Spade Stars, with nearly 375 million downloads and 22 million monthly active users across 17 live games. BestPlay, its in-house engagement platform, adds another 2.2 million monthly users and supports player acquisition and retention. For 2025, Bluetile and BestPlay reported combined revenue of \$153.6 million

(₹1,405 crore) and EBITDA of \$27.7 million (₹254 crore), reflecting steady growth driven by global expansion and scaling. Nazara CEO Nitish Mittersain said the acquisition would add strong synergies and support the company’s strategy of building AI-enabled, scalable gaming businesses. Bluetile is led by founder Raymond Stauffer, a former Google executive, along with a team with experience across global gaming firms. The transaction is expected to enhance Nazara’s global gaming footprint and accelerate the development and scaling of next-generation casual and social gaming titles.

Jayant Agro’s Pragati boosts yields, cuts water use in Gujarat castor farms

Our Bureau
Ahmedabad

Jayant Agro-Organics Ltd said its sustainability initiatives in Gujarat’s castor belt are delivering higher productivity with lower resource use, with farmers reporting 32 per cent higher yields and demonstration plots showing nearly 30 per cent lower water consumption. **businessline.** **Disclaimer:** Readers are requested to verify & make appropriate enquiries to satisfy themselves about the veracity of an advertisement before responding to any published in this newspaper. THE PUBLISHING PVT LTD, the Publisher & Owner of this newspaper, does not vouch for the authenticity of any advertisement or advertiser or for any of the advertiser’s products and/or services. In no event can the Owner, Publisher, Printer, Editor, Director/s, Employees of this newspaper/company be held responsible/liable in any manner whatsoever for any claims and/or damages for advertisements in this newspaper.

The company’s flagship Project Pragati, launched in 2016 with Arkema, BASF and Solidaridad, along with its extension i-Pragati, have certified over 13,500 farmers and brought more than 16,000 hectares under sustainable cultivation practices. The initiatives have cumulatively produced around 1.7 lakh tonnes of certified castor seeds, strengthening India’s position as a key supplier to global specialty chemical markets, with Gujarat accounting for the bulk of global castor output, the company stated. Beyond productivity gains, the programme focused on farmer resilience and supply chain traceability. During the year, over 450 training sessions were conducted, more than 500 lead farmers were trained, 10,000

safety kits distributed, and over 150 medical camps organised. **AT THE FARM LEVEL** Abhay Udeshi, Chairman, Jayant Agro, stated: “These initiatives reflect our long-standing belief that sustainability must be strengthened through active support from stakeholders at the farm level. Over the past nine years, they have demonstrated that responsible agricultural practices can enhance farmer incomes while ensuring a reliable and sustainable supply of castor for global industries. The continuous increase in the number of certified farmers is a testament to the trust they place in this model and reinforces India’s leadership in building resilient and sustainable supply chains.”

KKR’s \$310 m PMI deal reshapes India’s e-bus market

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

KKR’s decision to invest up to \$310 million in PMI Electro Mobility marks a turning point in India’s electric bus market, signalling a shift from vehicle manufacturing to capital-intensive, platform-led mobility models. The global investment firm will acquire a majority stake in Allfleet, PMI’s fleet management platform, alongside a minority stake in its manufacturing business. **FULL-STACK** The deal, KKR’s first in India under its Global Climate Transition strategy, positions PMI as a full-stack operator spanning manufacturing, fleet ownership and long-term operations, moving beyond the role of a conventional electric bus maker.



GROWTH PIVOT. The capital will be used to scale Allfleet’s portfolio to over 5,000 electric buses, funding procurement, deployment and lifecycle maintenance

The capital will be used to scale Allfleet’s portfolio to over 5,000 electric buses, funding procurement, deployment and lifecycle maintenance under the gross cost contract (GCC) model, where State transport undertakings pay operators per

kilometre, creating predictable, annuity-like revenue streams. “KKR’s investment is a strong endorsement of the integrated electric mobility platform we have developed at Allfleet,” said Aanchal Jain, Chief Executive, PMI

electro and Director at Allfleet. The investment comes amid rapid scale-up. PMI has emerged as the largest beneficiary of the government-backed PM E-DRIVE tender awarded in December 2025, securing 5,210 buses — nearly half of the 10,900 units allocated. It has already sold over 1,000 buses in FY26, capturing about 24 per cent market share, with an order book exceeding 8,200 units. More than 3,000 buses are already operational, giving PMI a lead in execution and fleet management. Financially, the ramp-up is significant. Revenues, estimated at ₹580-₹600 crore in FY25, are expected to more than double to ₹1,200-₹1,500 crore in FY26, with further upside as PM E-DRIVE deliveries accelerate. At scale, revenues could exceed ₹2,800 crore, support-

QUICKLY.
Nuclear doctrine unlikely to change, says Iran



Dubai: Iran's stance against the development of nuclear weapons will not significantly change, Foreign Minister Abbas Araqchi (*in picture*) told *Al Jazeera* in remarks relayed by Iranian media on Wednesday, cautioning that the new supreme leader is yet to publicly express his view on the matter. Western countries, including the US and Israel, have for years accused Tehran of seeking nuclear weapons, while the Iranian authorities have said their nuclear programme is solely for civilian purposes. Iran's Foreign Minister said he believed that after the war comes to an end, countries that border the Gulf should draft a new protocol for the Strait of Hormuz to ensure that safe passage through the narrow waterway is carried out under certain conditions aligned with Iranian and regional interests. **REUTERS**

‘Lack of plan for Hormuz Strait closure frustrating’



Madrid: The lack of a plan from the US and Israel to deal with the partial closure of the Strait of Hormuz by Iran was “frustrating”, said Britain's Chancellor Rachel Reeves on Wednesday. “It is frustrating there doesn't seem to be a plan for what to do now after the very predictable closure of the Strait,” Reeves told an event, alongside Spanish Economy Minister Carlos Cuerpo. **REUTERS**

Brent oil rises to \$109.75/barrel as Iran vows to target energy assets in W Asia

TOPSY-TURVY. Tehran to retaliate for US-Israel attack on South Pars gas field and associated facilities

Bloomberg

Oil and European natural gas prices surged as Iran listed energy assets in the region that it would target in response to a US and Israeli attack on its upstream industry.

Brent oil climbed as much as 6.1 per cent to a high of \$109.75 a barrel, while Europe's gas benchmark jumped as much as 9.1 per cent, according to data from ICE Futures Europe.

SOUTH PARS GAS FIELD

Iran said that the US and Israel attacked the South Pars gas field, as well as associated facilities at Asaluyeh. The assets are important for domestic supply and also shipments to neighbouring Iraq and Turkey.

In response, Tehran is-



IN A SHAMBLES. The site of an Israeli strike following an escalation between Hezbollah and Israel in Beirut on Wednesday

sued a list of similar assets in Saudi Arabia, Qatar and the UAE that it said residents should avoid.

The war has brought chaos across West Asia with the stakes for energy markets rising every day. As well as effectively halting the Strait of

Hormuz, the world's most important oil channel, the conflict has seen Iran lashing out across the region, lowering production.

The South Pars attack would mark the first on Iran's upstream facilities since the war began. While the US

struck oil export hub Kharg Island late last week, it limited that attack to military targets.

Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps responded by publishing a list of energy sites in Saudi Arabia, the UAE and Qatar that “have become direct and legitimate targets” following the attack on South Pars, the semi-official *Tasnim* news agency reported.

“New attacks bring the attention back to the physical supply reality of the war – curtailments in energy tighten every day,” said Rabobank's Energy Strategist Florence Schmit.

TARGET SITES

The sites that Iran listed, all of which have at least some kind of US interest, were the Ras Laffan refinery and Mesaieed petrochemical com-

plex in Qatar, Samref refinery and Jubail petrochemical complex in Saudi Arabia and the Al Hosn gas asset in the UAE.

ARAMCO FACILITIES

Saudi Aramco is evacuating the Samref and Jubail facilities as a precautionary measure after Iran issued a list of potential targets, according to a person familiar with the matter. A spokesperson for Aramco wasn't immediately available to comment.

Some other sites identified in the Iran list were also being evacuated, including the Al Hosn gas field in the UAE and the Mesaieed Petrochemical Complex in Qatar, according to separate people familiar with the matter.

Spokespeople for Adnoc and QatarEnergy didn't immediately respond.

‘Over 1.2 lakh PNG connections activated in 2 weeks’

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

The government has activated more than 1.2 lakh piped natural gas (PNG) connections for domestic, commercial and industrial users as well as CNG stations in the last two weeks, as the conflict in West Asia continues to disrupt India's LPG supplies, with commercial users facing the main brunt.

Besides, the State governments have lifted almost 7,200 tonnes of liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) in the last four days. Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary, Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas (MoPNG), during the brief-

ing on West Asia on Wednesday, said that priority sectors continue to receive protected gas supplies, including 100 per cent supply to domestic PNG and compressed natural gas (CNG) transport, while supplies to industrial and commercial consumers are being regulated at around 80 per cent.

‘SWITCH TO PNG’

Commercial LPG consumers are being encouraged to switch to PNG, and establish-

ments such as hotels, restaurants, hospitals and hostels can obtain PNG connections from authorised city gas distribution (CGD) entities. In the last two weeks, around 1.2 lakh

new PNG connections have been given, and this includes domestic, commercial, industrial and CNG stations, she added.

LPG supply continues to be monitored in view of the prevailing geopolitical situation, said Sharma, adding that domestic LPG production from refineries has been increased by about 40 per cent.

Besides, no dry-outs have been reported at distributorships. This would mean that compared to the average daily LPG production in February 2026 (37,929 tonnes), average daily output may have increased to roughly 53,100 tonnes.

About 15 States/ UTs such

as Bihar, Chhattisgarh Delhi, Gujarat, Haryana, Himachal Pradesh, Jharkhand, Karnataka, Kerala, Manipur, Rajasthan, Uttarakhand and others have issued orders for allocation of non-domestic LPG, and commercial LPG supply is being made available across the country.

Sharma emphasised that domestic LPG cylinder deliveries are continuing as normal, and instances of panic booking are reducing.

ONLINE BOOKING

While online LPG bookings have increased from 83 per cent to 93 per cent, the delivery authentication code coverage has expanded from 53 per cent (February 2026) to

about 81 per cent to prevent diversion. On the supply of petrol and diesel, Sharma informed that all refineries are operating at high capacity with adequate crude inventories. India has sufficient production of petrol and diesel, and no imports are required to meet domestic demand. No cases of fuel dry-outs have been reported.

On vessels idling around the Strait of Hormuz, Rakesh Kumar Sinha, Special Secretary, Shipping Ministry, said there are 22 ships west of the Strait. These vessels are loaded with roughly 3.2 lakh tonnes of LPG, two lakh tonnes of liquefied natural gas (LNG) and 16.7 lakh tonnes of crude oil.

Cabinet clears ₹33,660 crore scheme to set up 100 plug-and-play industrial parks

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The Union Cabinet on Wednesday approved a new industrial parks scheme, with an outlay of ₹33,660 crore, providing plug-and-play infrastructure for 100 industrial parks. This is to strengthen manufacturing, attract investments and create jobs. The Bharat Audyogik Vikas Yojna (BHAVYA) aims to create world-class industrial infrastructure and unlock India's manufacturing potential while generating about 15 lakh direct jobs, according to Ashwini Vaishnaw, Minister for Information and Broadcasting.

“It will create plug-and-play ecosystems, where industries can move from intent to production with speed and certainty,” said Vaishnaw at a media briefing on Wednesday.

NICDP FRAMEWORK

The scheme builds on the success of Industrial Smart Cities developed under the National Industrial Corridor

BHAVYA aims to create world-class industrial infra and unlock India's manufacturing potential while generating about 15 lakh direct jobs

Development Programme (NICDP) framework and will be implemented in partnership with the States and private sector players.

Under BHAVYA, industrial parks of 100 to 1,000 acres will be developed with financial support of up to ₹1 crore per acre. These parks will feature core infrastructure such as internal roads, underground utilities, drainage systems, common treatment facilities and ICT-enabled administrative systems. In addition, value-added facilities like ready-built factory sheds, built-to-suit units, testing labs, warehousing and worker housing

will be provided. The government will also extend support for external infrastructure, up to 25 per cent of project cost and ensure seamless connectivity with existing transport networks. Projects will be selected through a challenge mode, ensuring that only high-quality, reform-oriented and investment-ready proposals are taken forward.

At its core, BHAVYA seeks to improve ease of doing business through streamlined approvals and single-window systems, per the government. The parks will be aligned with PM Gati Shakti principles to ensure multimodal connectivity and efficient logistics, while also promoting green energy and sustainable resource use.

The initiative will be spearheaded by the National Industrial Corridor Development Corporation, which is currently implementing 20 projects across 13 States, and is expected to generate largescale employment while strengthening domestic supply chains.

Govt approves small hydropower policy

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The Union Cabinet on Wednesday approved the small hydro power (SHP) development scheme for the period FY27 to FY31, with an outlay of ₹2,584.60 crore for the installation of projects of an approximate capacity of 1,500 megawatt (MW).

The scheme will help set up small hydro projects (between 1 and 25 MW capacity) in different States, and will benefit hilly and North-Eastern States with high potential for such projects, said Pralhad Joshi, Ministry of New & Renewable Energy.

In the North-Eastern States and in districts with international borders, Central financial assistance to the tune of ₹3.6 crore per MW, or 30 per cent of the project cost, whichever is lower, with an upper limit of ₹30 crore per project, will be available. In other States, ₹2.4 crore per MW, or 20 per cent of the project cost, whichever is lower, with a cap of ₹20 crore per project, will be available. This will



MORE POWER. The scheme will help set up small hydro projects (between 1 and 25 MW capacity) in different States

help in tapping the small hydro potential in remote and difficult to reach locations.

the objective of Aatmanirbhar Bharat.

PROJECT REPORTS

The scheme will also incentivise the States to prepare the detailed project report for about 200 projects to create a pipeline for small hydro projects in future. An amount of ₹30 crore has been earmarked to support State and Central government agencies to prepare such reports.

PHDCCI Secretary General Ranjeet Mehta said this marks a targeted push towards decentralised renewable energy, in the wake of

States promoting PNG connections to get 10% more commercial LPG

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

In a significant development, the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas (MoPNG) has proposed to the States that they will receive 10 per cent more liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) if they promote piped natural gas (PNG) and effect transition from cylinders to piped gas.

As the conflict in West Asia intensifies, India has been working on various fronts to ensure LPG supply, considering that 60 per cent of its imports transit the Strait of Hormuz.

The closure of the critical energy chokepoint has resulted in rationing of LPG, with priority being given to households with 100 per cent supply. PSU oil marketing companies (OMCs) are providing 20 per cent commercial LPG to the States.

The Oil Ministry has proposed to the States that even while LPG for commercial use is in short supply, the allocation could be increased to 30 per cent, provided the States transition to PNG in the long-term.

To be eligible for the increase of 10 per cent (over and above the 20 per cent allocation), the State has to carry out a set of reforms to reduce LPG consumption in the long run and enhance PNG penetration, said Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary at the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas (MoPNG).

DISTRICT PANELS

The Oil Ministry has proposed 1 per cent additional allocation if the State government forms empowered district-level committees with local body executive representation to approve city gas distribution (CGD) applications and resolve grievances. Another 2 per



As the conflict in West Asia intensifies, India has been working on various fronts to ensure the supply of LPG

cent additional allocation will be given for issuing orders for granting deemed CGD permissions to all pending applications, as well as new applications, after the lapse of 24 hours of application for laying pipeline or within the said period through the State single-window scheme.

DIG AND RESTORE PLAN

An additional 3 per cent allocation will be made for introducing a ‘dig and restore scheme’ for CGD entities so they can dig and restore on their own, eliminate restoration charges and substitute them with a bank guarantee of up to a maximum of ₹10 lakh per kilometre to ensure satisfactory restoration of digging/laying of pipelines. Finally, the Centre will offer 4 per cent additional allocation to the States for reducing the annual rental/ lease charges for laying/ operating CGD network to zero.

Due to the efforts made by the Oil Ministry, GAIL has increased the allocation to PNG for the commercial sector to 100 per cent in a bid to provide relief and transition this sector to natural gas from LPG.

‘Iranian govt degraded but appears intact’

Reuters
Washington

Iran's government has been degraded since the war began on February 28, but it appears to be intact and Tehran and its proxies remain capable of attacking US and allies' interests in West Asia, said US Director of National Intelligence Tulsi Gabbard on Wednesday.

“The regime in Iran appears to be intact but largely degraded by Operation Epic Fury,” said Gabbard, referring to the US-Israel military campaign against Iran, in her opening statement to the Senate Intelligence Committee's annual hearing on Worldwide Threats to the US. “Even so, Iran and its proxies remain capable of and continue to attack US and allied interests in West Asia. If a hostile regime survives, it will seek to begin a years-long effort to rebuild its missiles and UAV (drone) forces,” she said.

The hearing was expected to focus on the Iran war, now in its third week, as lawmakers, including some of President Donald Trump's fellow Republicans as well as Democrats, have said they want more information about an air campaign that has killed thousands of people, disrupted the lives of millions and shaken energy and stock markets.

Democrats in particular have complained that the administration has not kept Congress adequately informed about a conflict that has cost US taxpayers billions, and demanded public testimony rather than classified briefings held in the past two weeks.

The testimony from officials, including Gabbard and CIA Director John Ratcliffe, is also likely to touch on the shock announcement on Tuesday that a top aide to Gabbard had resigned, citing the war. Joe Kent, who headed the National Counterterrorism Center, is the first senior official in Trump's administration to resign over the conflict.

Surge in polymer prices puts plastic industry in a spot

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Plastic product prices across sectors are expected to rise from April if the short supply of key raw materials continues amid the ongoing war in West Asia.

The prices of polymers, derived largely from crude oil and natural gas, have risen sharply in the last few days, leaving the plastic industry in a bind. The industry has already seen a 50-60 per cent rise in polymer prices, and expects it to stabilise at the current level.

Arvind M Mehta, Chairman of All India Plastics Manufacturers Association, said the industry has an inventory of 15-20 days, and the rise in costs is being passed on to end consumers



The industry is exploring 20 new markets, including Mexico, France, Brazil, Italy, the Netherlands, Japan and Belgium

through marginal price hikes, but the real challenge will only arise if the war is prolonged. “We have also taking fresh orders only from

corporates that are open to price revisions. If the war ends by March-end and supply chain becomes normal, the repercussion will be there for next 45 days,” he said on the sidelines of an event to launch Plastiworld 2026, a B2B event, from March 23.

RECOMMENDATIONS

Sunil Shah, President, AIPMA, said the trade body had submitted various recommendations to the government, including the release of 20 per cent higher working capital, as was done during the Covid period.

“We have also requested the government to reduce GST from 18 per cent to 10 per cent, so that there will be more money in the hands of corporates,” he added.

The demand has already

slowed 25-30 per cent due to rising prices, and this will decline further if the war persists, said Shah. The demand slowdown was felt most in the automotive, agricultural and packaging sectors.

DOMESTIC SLOWDOWN

The industry is focusing on exports to new markets following the recent signing of free trade agreements.

The global trade of finished plastic products is estimated at \$1.3 trillion, while India's exports account for \$12.5 billion, representing just 1 per cent of the global market. The US alone imports plastic products worth over \$72 billion annually.

The industry is exploring 20 new markets, including Mexico, France, Brazil, Italy, the Netherlands, Japan, the UK and Belgium.

Indian-flagged Jag Laadki docks at Mundra Port with UAE crude oil

Our Bureau
Ahmedabad

The Indian-flagged crude oil tanker *Jag Laadki* arrived at Mundra Port, part of Adani Ports and Special Economic Zone (APSEZ), in Gujarat on Wednesday, carrying approximately 80,886 tonnes of crude oil sourced from the UAE.

ENERGY SECURITY

The tanker's arrival comes amid heightened tensions in West Asia, particularly around the Strait of Hormuz, a crucial chokepoint for global crude shipments.

Such deliveries are vital for India's refineries to maintain uninterrupted op-



SAFE PASSAGE. The tanker's arrival comes amid heightened tensions in West Asia, particularly around the Strait of Hormuz

erations and safeguard energy security despite regional instability.

The vessel, loaded at Fujairah Port, measures 274.19 m in length and 50.04 m in beam, with a deadweight tonnage of 164,716 tonnes and gross tonnage of 84,735

tonnes, highlighting the port's ability to handle largescale crude shipments.

In the past two days, two LPG tankers carrying LPG from West Asia also arrived at Mundra and Kandla ports, having transited the Strait of Hormuz.

WHAT’S HOT: GADGETS.

Budget gold

The OPPO A6s 5G centres on battery capacity and entry-level imaging and features a 6.75-inch display. It packs a 6,500 mAh battery with 45 W



SUPERVOOC fast charging, with claimed standby of up to 882.1 hours and 22.4 hours of video playback. Camera hardware includes a 50 MP main sensor with a 2 MP secondary lens, alongside a 5 MP front camera for selfies and video calls. The device is powered by the MediaTek Dimensity 6300 chipset and runs on ColorOS 15, which brings system-level optimisation for smoother animations and app handling. The phone is 8.61 mm thick, weighs around 212 g and is offered in Aurora Gold and Plum Purple finishes. It is priced ₹18,999 for the 4GB + 128GB variant and ₹20,999 for the 6GB + 128GB variant.

Fitness wear

Beats and Nike announced the first hardware collaboration — Powerbeats Pro 2 - Nike Special Edition. The Powerbeats Pro 2 - Nike Special



Edition focuses on fitness use and design changes. The earbuds feature Adaptive Active Noise Cancelling and Transparency mode for audio control in different environments. Battery life is rated at up to 45 hours with the charging case, along with IPX4-rated sweat and water resistance for workouts. The design includes wrap-around earhooks aimed to securely fit during movement. The special edition introduces a matte black charging case with a Volt-speckled finish. It is priced ₹29,900 and will be available online in the US, the UK and India from March 20 via Apple.com and online.

Budget snap

Fujifilm India announced the launch of instax mini 13, an entry-level model in the instax series of instant cameras. The mini 13 is an analogue



instant camera that enhances the design and features of its predecessor, enabling users to easily and beautifully capture images. The camera body features a pop-inspired design with a soft, rounded 3D form, making it an item users will want to carry with them as a fashion accessory. It will be available from March 31, 2026, onwards, priced ₹10,999.

Power Max

POCO has launched the POCO X8 Pro Series. In the lineup, the POCO X8 Pro Max debuts in India as the first smartphone powered by the



Dimensity 9500s flagship chipset. Built on a 3 nm architecture, the chipset features a 1+3+4 all big-core CPU design with clock speeds reaching 3.73 GHz. Paired with LPDDR5X Ultra RAM and UFS 4.1 storage, the device ensures smooth responsiveness for switching between apps, editing content or streaming media. The POCO X8 Pro Max features a 9000 mAh battery. It is priced ₹42,999 (12GB + 256GB) and ₹46,999 (12GB + 512GB).

TECH DIGEST.

GPT-5.4 mini, nano out now

OpenAI has released GPT-5.4 mini and nano, bringing many of the strengths of GPT-5.4 to faster, more efficient models designed for



high-volume workloads. GPT-5.4 mini is an improvement over the GPT-5 mini across coding, reasoning, multimodal understanding and tool use, while GPT-5.4 nano is the smallest, cheapest version of GPT-5.4 for tasks that requires speed and cost matter most. It can be used for classification, data extraction, ranking and coding subagents that handle simpler supporting tasks. GPT-5.4 mini is available today in the API, Codex and ChatGPT.

Tinder unveils new AI features

Tinder unveiled its most significant product evolution in years — AI-powered personalisation, smarter safety systems and



new social formats designed to improve how people connect online and offline. Tinder also announced LLM-powered upgrades to its safety tools such as *Are You Sure?* and *Does This Bother You?* enabling context-aware detection of harmful language and introducing auto-blur for potentially disrespectful messages.

Apple launches AirPods Max 2

Apple recently launched the AirPods Max 2. Powered by H2, AirPods Max are better than ever with more effective ANC, enhanced sound



quality and new features such as Adaptive Audio and Live Translation. The AirPods Max 2 will be available to order starting March 25 in midnight, starlight, orange, purple and blue, with availability from next month. It is priced ₹67,900.

Samsung hits peak Android, yet again

SAMSUNG GALAXY S26 ULTRA. The perfect blend of cutting edge hardware and an intuitive user experience

Ashwin Rajagopalan

If you're a tennis buff, you might remember a phase when Roger Federer held the ATP number one ranking for a record 237 weeks in a row. Samsung's Galaxy S series Ultra flagship might remind you of the Federer era. For a while now, the Ultra has been the Android flagship to beat, further augmented by the integration of the design and productivity features of the Galaxy Note series (particularly the S-Pen) with the Galaxy S22 Ultra back in 2022. Almost ever since, the Ultra has seen mostly incremental upgrades even as Samsung's Android flagship rivals have been upping their game. The Samsung Galaxy S26 Ultra, the brand's latest flagship, is still the best Android show in town. And yet there's a feeling of déjà vu.

DESIGN

The Samsung Galaxy S26 Ultra screams premium. It's one of the most gorgeous Android slabs that keeps getting refined each year.

This year, Samsung ditched titanium (just like Apple did with the iPhone 17 Pro models) for an aluminium frame. It makes the S26 Ultra a tad lighter (214 g) and much nicer to hold thanks to excellent weight management. Samsung's signature S-Pen is ready on call, tucked away in the left bottom corner of the device. The other welcome design update is the new glass camera island that allows the rear camera module to integrate more seamlessly with the device.

CAMERA

The Ultra has been one of the most formidable mobile shooters on planet Android. But just like Federer's competitors who began to emerge after his dream run, we're seeing Chinese flagships challenge Samsung's camera hegemony with advanced hardware and imaging partnerships. On paper, the S26 Ultra hasn't made big changes to last year's S25 Ultra. The rear cam combines a 200 MP primary lens with a 50 MP ultra-wide lens, a 50 MP 5x periscope telephoto and a 10 MP 3x telephoto cam. There's one significant change though; the 200 MP lens now comes with a f/1.4 aperture and the telephoto camera features a f/2.9 aperture. The Ultra series has been one of our favourite smartphone cameras in lowlight; this update improves the S26 Ultra's low-light performance over its predecessors.

The S26 Ultra is one of the most fully loaded mobile shooters out there. It aced our tests across lighting scenarios with improved performance in lowlight videos. It may not be the best smartphone camera across scenarios — some of its



HIDDEN BRILLIANCE. Samsung's much touted Privacy Display with Flex Magic Pixel technology (to limit viewing angles) is the star of the show ASHWIN RAJAGOPALAN



The camera captures great details even in low light



Lowlight images are impressive



10x zoom image of the Mumbai skyline from a flight

Chinese rivals have pulled ahead in the zoom photography department — and yet its versatility and post image capture AI tools make it a formidable option.

DISPLAY

Samsung's much touted Privacy Display with Flex Magic Pixel technology (to limit viewing angles) is the star of the show. It prevents curious onlookers from viewing your screen from the side. It's a great feature to counter 'peepers' in flight cabins and other crowded spots. While privacy screen protectors have been around, this feature allows the S26 Ultra to maintain full display quality. Samsung allows you to turn this off and also increase the privacy with a maximum setting. We like how the privacy display can be activated only

for specific apps allowing your friendly neighbours to 'shoulder surf' when you feel more social. The Privacy Display is one of the best features of the S26 Ultra, a seamless blend of hardware and software execution. Aside from this new feature, the Ultra's 6.9-inch QHD+ Dynamic AMOLED LTPO 2x display remains one of the best on any smartphone. Colours come alive when you set the screen resolution to the QHD+ mode with excellent visibility even under direct sunlight.

PERFORMANCE

The S26 Ultra is powered by a Qualcomm Snapdragon Elite Gen 5 chipset for Galaxy. We checked out the 12 GB/256 GB variant (the device also comes in 12 GB/512 GB and 16 GB/1 TB options); it blazed

through our tests, consistently clocking above 11,300 on our Geekbench (multi-core) benchmark test. Samsung's One UI 8.5 sits atop Android 16 and adds to the device's appeal. It offers a heap of customisations and AI tools.

While some of the image editing tools are handy, you might not use some of them such as the Now Nudge. It's 2026, most brands are leaning on AI for their sales pitch; however, it remains a work in progress. It's still not the primary reason that influences buying decisions. Battery life (there's a 5000 mAh battery under the hood) is solid, and managed over a day of extensive use including camera, video sessions and calls.

VERDICT

The Samsung Galaxy S26 Ultra re-

mains one of our favourite Android slabs. It fires on all cylinders; it's a great work + play device with cutting edge hardware and a stellar camera. Aside from the useful privacy display, it's not a major step up from its predecessors but it's still the most well-rounded Android flagship that seems to have hit its peak. The big question is, what next? 2027 is not too far away.

● SNAPSHOT

Price: ₹1,39,999 onwards
Pros: Privacy display, best of breed hardware, camera performance
Cons: No significant upgrades over its predecessor

Ashwin Rajagopalan

Apple's carefully structured product line often draws comparisons with a luxury car maker. Nowhere is this comparison more relevant than the iPhone. At the top end of the pyramid is the iPhone 17 Pro Max with a starting price of ₹1,49,900 while the cheapest current generation iPhone is priced ₹64,900. The iPhone 17e takes over the mantle of the baseline iPhone from last year's 16e. Most value conscious smartphone buyers are likely to ask whether this device is all the iPhone you need; that's a question likely to elicit a nuanced answer.

DESIGN

At a time when clunky smartphones are passé, the iPhone 17e's compact form factor is a clear win. It's a throwback to the simple joys of one-handed navigation. At 170 g, it's almost as light as the slinky iPhone Air. Apple has added a new colour way, Soft Pink, that's one of the best shades of pink on any smartphone right now. This device is geared for your adventures thanks to its IP68 certification (for dust and water resistance) and a Ceramic Shield 2 display for scratch resistance.

DISPLAY

Apple's Notch that we first saw in the iPhone X lives on in the 17e, making it the only current generation iPhone without the pill-shaped 'Dynamic Island' that now sits on the top corner of newer iPhone displays. The 17e sticks with the same 60Hz refresh rate that we saw on the 2025 iPhone 16e. It's one of the key differences between the 17e and the iPhone 17 that comes with a 120Hz ProMotion display.

I switched from an iPhone 17 Pro Max to the iPhone 17e. While the difference was more evident while I was scrolling through my Ins-

All the iPhone you need?

IPHONE 17E. Compact form, stellar performance and a future-proof ticket to the Apple ecosystem



TALKING POINTS. The iPhone will please heavy duty users as it consistently clocked above 9,000 in our Geekbench benchmark (multi-core) tests ASHWIN RAJAGOPALAN

tagram feed, it didn't matter much in a couple of days when I got used to this smaller display. It's a difference most iPhone users looking to upgrade from older iPhones such as the iPhone 11 are unlikely to notice but could matter to screen snobs, serious gamers or Android users moving from more immersive displays.

I watched the Season 3 finale of *Tehran* on this 6.1-inch OLED display (that peaks at 1200 nits); the

colours were punchy and the audio was quite impressive too.

CAMERA

It's not just the display; the camera is another feature that's likely to spark some debate. We think it comes down to utility vs actual performance. The rear camera duties are handled by a 48 MP (f/1.6) lens; there's also a 12 MP selfie shooter in the mix. At a time when triple rear cams are the standard fare, the



Lifelike colours in optimal light



Indoor images are sharp

lack of an ultra-wide lens or a dedicated telephoto lens might seem a misstep but it actually boils down to your use case scenarios. The rear cam shoots great pictures and videos in most lighting scenarios, the 2x zoom gives you extra control especially when you shoot portraits. The 17e impressed with its portraits offering a natural bokeh and clear subject separation in our tests.

PERFORMANCE

The biggest changes in the iPhone 17e (vis-à-vis its predecessor) are under the hood. One of the talking points of this smartphone is the Apple A19 chip (with a 4-core GPU) that also propels the iPhone 17, giving this device a huge edge over most of its rivals. It will please heavy duty users as it consistently clocked above 9,000 in our Geekbench benchmark (multi-core) tests. Apple has bumped up the base storage to 256 GB while retaining the same launch price as last year's iPhone 16e. I tried editing short videos on LumaFusion, and it didn't break a sweat.

The iPhone 17e scores on battery performance. It lasted about a day and a half with moderate to heavy usage. Apple has added MagSafe support to the 17e, offering 15 W wireless charging with compatible chargers and also allowing you to

connect with a whole ecosystem of MagSafe accessories, such as wallets and charging docks.

VERDICT

The iPhone 17e makes some thoughtful enhancements over its predecessor, including increased internal storage, MagSafe support and improved durability with Ceramic Shield 2. The device covers key bases for buyers looking at moving to the Apple ecosystem and older iPhone users looking at the most affordable iPhone with future-proof features, such as support for Apple Intelligence. If a versatile camera and a more immersive display are deal breakers for you, then the iPhone 17 (that comes at a ₹18,000 premium over the 17e) might still be the better option. The iPhone 17e might be all the iPhone most average users need; are you one those average users?

● SNAPSHOT

Price: ₹64,900 onwards
Pros: Dependable camera, compact form, zippy and future-proof chipset, iOS experience
Cons: No ultra-wide lens, display with a 60Hz refresh rate

QUICKLY.
LS okays demands for grants for Ministries



New Delhi: The Lok Sabha on Wednesday passed the demands for grants of various Ministries for 2026-27, approving an expenditure of over ₹53 lakh crore. The House passed the Demands for Grants by applying the guillotine. Earlier, the Lok Sabha discussed the Demands for Grants for the Ministries of Railways, and Agriculture and Farmers' Welfare. **PH**

RBI to conduct ₹75,000 cr 3-day VRR auction

Mumbai: The Reserve Bank of India on Wednesday said it will conduct a three-day variable rate repo (VRR) auction of ₹75,000 crore on March 20. The auction will take place between 9.30 am and 10 am on March 20, and the reversal of these funds will take place on March 23, as per the central bank's release. The central bank announced the auction based on the current and evolving liquidity conditions of the banking system, the release added. **PH**

India holds firm on food stockholding as WTO draft sidesteps key issues

IN CRITICAL PHASE. Discussions on agriculture may get tricky at Yaounde Ministerial meet this month

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

India will continue to push for prioritising a long-pending permanent solution on public stockholding (PSH) at the upcoming WTO Ministerial Conference in Yaounde, Cameroon, later this month as it remains critical for safeguarding its MSP-based food security programmes from potential legal challenges in the future, sources said.

The draft Ministerial text on agriculture, circulated on March 16 during a special session of the WTO's agriculture committee, stops short of explicitly addressing PSH or the Special Safeguard Mechanism (SSM), both key demands of India and several developing countries. Instead, it makes a broad reference to past Ministerial decisions without spelling out a clear path forward on these issues.

US' APPROACH

The draft also reflects a partial accommodation of the US push for a "new ap-



DEMANDS IGNORED. The draft Ministerial text on agriculture stops short of explicitly addressing public stockholding or the special safeguard mechanism, both key demands of India and several developing countries **REUTERS**

proach" to agriculture negotiations seen by many developing members as an attempt to dilute existing mandates. While it includes this as one of the possible ways forward, it simultaneously underscores continuity by noting that both "existing and future contributions" of members will shape the negotiations. "... The negotiations shall continue on the basis of Members' existing and future contributions, including proposals on possible new

approaches to advance the negotiations," the draft states. Sources said India has taken up the issue of the absence of a direct mention of PSH and SSM in the draft Ministerial declaration and underlined its importance for developing countries and the fact that it has been pending for almost a decade. "The main lacuna in the draft is the failure to specifically mention and reaffirm the mandated issues where work is already advanced, such as PSH, SSM, cotton and do-

mestic support. While an MC14 declaration must reflect and consolidate the positions of all members, it must also recognise the interests of the majority of members," said Ranja Sengupta from the Third World Network. At the WTO, PSH is treated as trade-distorting support and capped at 10 per cent of the value of production (for developing countries), calculated using outdated 1980s reference prices. This makes countries like In-

dia appear to breach limits (as in rice) even when support is modest in real terms. A temporary "peace clause" agreed at the 2013 Bali Ministerial protects developing countries from legal action if conditions are met, but these are onerous and leave them exposed to uncertainty and potential disputes, underscoring the need for the permanent solution promised at Bali.

CORE CONCERN

With the US now insisting on a new approach for agricultural negotiations at the WTO, India and other developing countries have to guard against getting the pending issues brushed under the carpet.

"India had so far been insisting that pending issues such as the PSH, the SSM and cotton should be addressed before new issues are brought into the mandate for discussion.

"It needs to keep up the pressure on developed countries, including the US, to ensure that the past mandate remain relevant," another expert pointed out.

Lloyd's of London to set up operations in Gift City

Avinash Nair
Ahmedabad



GAINING MOMENTUM. Lloyd's move to set up base in Gujarat could boost Gift City's access to global underwriting capital and deepen its risk-management capabilities

Marking a landmark step in positioning India's IFSC as a regional hub for cross-border reinsurance, UK-based insurance and reinsurance powerhouse Lloyd's of London, renowned for underwriting some of the world's most complex and high-value risks, is set to establish operations in Gujarat International Finance Tec-City (Gift City) in Gujarat. The application is for the establishment of a statutory insurance and reinsurance corporation, authorised to undertake insurance and reinsurance business under the IFSCA Registration of

Insurance Business Regulations, 2021, with funds to be remitted from Lloyd's head office in London. Officials from IFSCA told *businessline* that Lloyd's proposal is currently "under process".

UNDERWRITING ACCESS

Lloyd's is one of the world's most influential underwrit-

ing centres for complex risks across sectors such as shipping, aviation, energy and catastrophe insurance. The move to set up base in Gujarat could dramatically boost Gift City's access to global underwriting capital, deepen its risk-management capabilities and signal India's rising significance on

the global reinsurance map. Lloyd's declined to comment on the development. Gift City gives Indian insurers access to global reinsurers but legal control often lies overseas, making careful contract drafting essential for managing cross-border disputes. "When a Lloyd's syndicate writes reinsurance out of Gift City, the contract may be signed in Gujarat but the capital, the counterparty and the enforcement architecture sit in the City of London. That structural reality is what makes Lloyd's entry into Gift City significant beyond the headline — and it is where the more complex questions begin. The more complex shift is not regulat-

ory but contractual. When reinsurance contracts are written out of Gift City but backed by capital and counterparties sitting outside India, the question is no longer where the contract is signed but where the risk actually resides," says Prachi Shrivastava, Founder of law practice development firm Lawfinity Solutions. She explained that even if the insured asset and the primary insurer are in India, disputes under these contracts will often be handled abroad — in London or Singapore — because that is where the global reinsurers are comfortable enforcing claims. While the IFSCA framework governs the local en-

tity, it is ultimately the contract that dictates dispute resolution, creating a layered situation where the risk is in India but legal control sits overseas.

GLOBAL PLAYERS LINE UP

Another key entrant in GIFT City is Echo Reinsurance Ltd, based in Zurich, which was granted approval this month to open a branch in GIFT IFSC, where it will undertake reinsurance business. Beyond Lloyd's and Echo, global insurance and reinsurance majors from South Korea, the UK, Singapore, Saudi Arabia, the UAE, and Kazakhstan have either lined up or received approval to establish operations in Gift City.

Indian Bank plans to raise ₹5,000 cr via infra bonds this month-end

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai



Binod Kumar, MD & CEO, Indian Bank

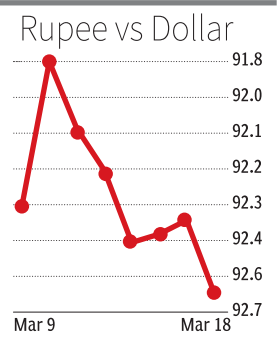
Indian Bank plans to raise around ₹5,000 crore from the bond market by way of infrastructure bonds by this month-end with the public sector bank also securing the necessary board approvals for this particular fundraise on Wednesday. "We had already got an enabling approval from the board to raise ₹5,000 crore during the financial year and today the board has also approved the proposal for this particular fundraise by way of infrastructure bonds," Binod Kumar, Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer (MD & CEO) of the Chennai-headquartered Indian Bank, told *businessline*. "We felt the current period to be the right opportunity; we have identified investors and see good appet-

ite to close the funding by the end of March," he added. Raising money primarily for infrastructure lending, the PSU bank sees good demand for infrastructure credit, especially in green finance, battery storage, data centre and other projects. This is Indian Bank's first time tapping the bond mar-

kets in this fiscal year. Earlier in October 2024, the bank had raised ₹5,000 crore through 10-year infrastructure bonds. Indian Bank's plans to raise funds from the bond market follows a slew of such fundraise by other PSU banks, including Union Bank of India, Bank of Baroda, Bank of India and State Bank of India. Analysts say these moves follow the significant demand and appetite that banks see for infrastructure lending to support long-term projects, especially in the renewable energy space. "Banks had not tapped the bond market till about first 8 months or so of this fiscal, but since then we have seen a pick-up," he said. Deposit growth has come down and while Certificate of Deposits issuance had increased, it is more short-term, leaving only the infra bonds route, he added.

₹ plunges to record low of 92.63/dollar

Our Bureau
Mumbai



The rupee declined to an all-time closing low on Wednesday, weighed down by concerns arising from rising crude oil prices due to the escalating war in West Asia, capital outflows, including FPI related, from the Indian financial markets and strengthening US dollar. The Indian currency closed at 92.63 per US dollar, down 26 paise against the previous close of 92.37. Amit Pabari, MD, CR Forex Advisors, said the rupee closed at yet another record low on March 18, extending its recent losing streak as a mix of global and domestic headwinds continues to weigh on the currency. "At the core of this weakness is the intensifying Middle East conflict, which has kept crude oil prices elevated — a key concern for an oil-import-dependent economy like India," he said.

"As geopolitical tensions escalated, foreign investor sentiment turned sharply negative. Overseas portfolio investors have pulled out over \$9.8 billion from Indian markets, marking a sharp reversal from February's inflow of \$4.2 billion. This swing in flows has reduced dollar inflows significantly, adding direct pressure on the rupee," he said. At the same time, rising global uncertainty has supported the US dollar, which continues to hold firm above 99.50 (Dollar Index).

CIBIL score monitoring hits 183 m in Dec

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The number of Indians actively self-monitoring their CIBIL score reached 183 million as of December 2025, with first-time monitors growing 27 per cent year-on-year, according to a report released by TransUnion CIBIL, India's credit information company. The data, drawn from the company's annual report 'CIBIL for every Indian', show that credit monitoring has shifted from a loan-driven, one-time activity to a routine financial habit. Nearly 45 per cent of consumers who monitored their

scores improved their scores within six months, and the average CIBIL score among this group was 728. Non-metro regions are driving the bulk of this growth, accounting for 75 per cent of all monitoring consumers and recording 28 per cent year-on-year expansion. These markets also lead in credit quality, with 73 per cent of consumers holding a prime score of 731 or above residing outside major urban centres. **GEN Z LEADS ADOPTION** Among demographic groups, Gen Z showed the sharpest rise, with monitoring activity growing 1.41 times faster

than other segments. The cohort now represents 29 per cent of the total monitoring base. Post-monitoring, Gen Z borrowers shifted toward secured credit products — gold loan originations among them rose 61 per cent year-on-year, while two-wheeler loans in semi-urban and rural areas grew 23 per cent. **WOMEN OUTPACE MEN** Women recorded a 38 per cent year-on-year increase in credit monitoring, outpacing men by 13 percentage points. Around 63 per cent of monitoring women hold a prime credit score, and 71 per cent of newly monitoring women are from non-metro regions.

StanChart reviews offers from Federal Bank, Kotak to buy credit card-only customers

Reuters
Mumbai

Standard Chartered is reviewing offers from Kotak Mahindra Bank and Federal Bank to acquire the British lender's up to 6 lakh customers in India who only have credit card accounts, two sources with knowledge of the matter said. The potential divestment is part of StanChart's strategy to reduce focus on single-product clients, they said. The London-based lender has been offloading non-core components of its portfolio in India to improve

its profitability. Last year, Standard Chartered sold its India personal loan business, that at the time was valued at \$488 million, to Kotak Mahindra Bank. Kotak and Federal have submitted final offers for acquiring StanChart's India portfolio of credit card-only customers, who have no other relationship with the bank and are considered non-core to its business, said the two sources, who declined to be named as the deal talks are private. The financial details of Kotak and Federal's proposals were not immediately clear. The Indian lenders and

Standard Chartered did not respond to requests for comment. "StanChart is currently reviewing both of these offers and it is expected to take some time," one of the sources said, adding that the potential sale does not indicate that the bank is completely exiting the credit card business. The move is linked to the bank's strategy to get rid of "non-core accounts", the person said. StanChart's plan to sell the portfolio of cards has been reported. But *Reuters* is first to report that Kotak and Federal are in the race for it.

RBI clears Bain Capital's ₹4,385 crore investment in Manappuram Finance arms

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Manappuram Finance Ltd (MFL) said its subsidiaries — Asirvad Micro Finance Ltd (AMFL) and Manappuram Home Finance Ltd (MHFL) — have received the requisite approvals from the Reserve Bank of India for indirect change in control and management of the respective companies. This comes in the wake of the proposed investment of about ₹4,385 crore in the gold loan company by Bain Capital's affiliates. With this, MFL and its subsidiaries are now in receipt of all requisite statutory approvals for Bain Capital's proposed investment (through affiliates BC

Asia Investments XXV Ltd and BC Asia Investments XIV Ltd) in the company and acquisition of joint control with the existing promoters, together with the consequent open offer under the SEBI (Substantial Acquisition of Shares and Takeovers) Regulations, 2011, per the gold loan company's regulatory filing. "Having now received all requisite statutory approvals, the company (MFL) and Bain Capital will aim to complete the capital infusion in the company by March 31, 2026 and Bain Capital intends to complete the open offer in accordance with the timelines prescribed under the SEBI (Substantial Acquisition of Shares and Takeovers) Regulations, 2011," it said.



IDFC FIRST Bank Limited

CIN: L65110TN2014PLC097792

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Website: www.idfcfirst.bank.in; **E-mail:** bank.info@idfcfirstbank.com

POSTAL BALLOT NOTICE

NOTICE is hereby given to the Shareholders ("Members") of IDFC FIRST Bank Limited (the "Bank" or "IDFC FIRST Bank") that pursuant to Sections 108, 110, and other applicable provisions, if any, of the Companies Act, 2013, (the "the Act"), read with Rules 20 and 22 of the Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014, and General Circular Nos. 14/2020 dated April 08, 2020, 17/2020 dated April 13, 2020, 09/2024 dated September 19, 2024 and 03/2025 dated September 22, 2025, read with other relevant circulars issued by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs and the Securities and Exchange Board of India (*hereinafter collectively referred to as the "Relevant Circulars"*), Regulation 44 and other applicable provisions, if any, of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 ("**SEBI Listing Regulations**"), Secretarial Standard on General Meetings ("**SS-2**"), and other applicable laws, including any statutory amendment(s), modification(s), variation(s) or re-enactment(s) thereof, for the time being in force, the following special business is proposed to be passed by the Members of the Bank through Postal Ballot via remote electronic voting ("**Remote e-Voting**") only.

Sr. No.	Description of the Resolution	Type of Resolution
1.	Re-appointment of Mr. S. Ganesh Kumar (DIN: 07635860) as an Independent Director of the Bank.	Special Resolution

In accordance with the Relevant Circulars, the Bank has completed the dispatch of Notice of Postal Ballot along with the Explanatory Statement ("**Postal Ballot Notice**") on March 18, 2026, in electronic mode to those Members whose names appeared in the Register of Members / List of Beneficial Owners as on **Friday, March 13, 2026 ("Cut-off Date")**, received from the National Securities Depository Limited ("**NSDL**") and the Central Depository Services (India) Limited ("**CDSL**") (*collectively referred to as "Depositories"*), and whose e-mail address is registered with the Bank/ KFin Technologies Limited ("**KFintech**"). Registrar and Transfer Agent of the Bank ("**RTA**")/ Depositories/ Depository Participants.

In compliance with the Relevant Circulars, the physical copy of the Postal Ballot Notice along with postal ballot form and pre-paid business reply envelope will not be sent to the Members. Accordingly, the communication of assent or dissent of the Members eligible to vote in respect of the aforesaid resolution is restricted only to remote e-Voting, i.e., by casting their votes electronically instead of submitting postal ballot forms.

A copy of the Postal Ballot Notice is also available on the website of the Bank at www.idfcfirst.bank.in, the websites of the Stock Exchanges where the equity shares of the Bank are listed, i.e., "BSE Limited" ("**BSE**") at www.bseindia.com and "National Stock Exchange of India Limited" ("**NSE**") at www.nseindia.com and the website of NSDL at www.evoting.nsdl.com, who is the remote e-Voting service providing agency to the Bank.

PROCESS OF REGISTRATION OF E-MAIL ADDRESSES:

Members holding shares in dematerialized mode are requested to register/ update their KYC details including e-mail address with the relevant Depository Participants. Members holding shares in physical form are requested to register/ update their KYC details including e-mail address by submitting duly filled and signed Form ISR-1 at <https://ris.kfintech.com/clientservices/isc/default.aspx> along with the copy of the share certificate (front and back), self-attested copy of the PAN card and such other documents as prescribed in the Form. Form ISR-1 is available on the website of the Bank at <https://www.idfcfirst.bank.in/investors>

PROCEDURE FOR REMOTE E-VOTING:

The Bank has engaged with NSDL for facilitating remote e-Voting to enable the Members to cast their votes electronically in respect of the resolution as set out in the Postal Ballot Notice.

The remote e-voting facility will be available during the period as given below:

Commencement of Remote e-voting	Thursday, March 19, 2026, at 9.00 a.m. IST
End of Remote e-voting	Friday, April 17, 2026, at 5.00 p.m. IST

During the above period, Members holding shares either in physical form or in dematerialized form as on cut-off date, i.e., **Friday, March 13, 2026**, may cast their vote electronically. The remote e-Voting facility shall be disabled by NSDL after closure of remote e-Voting period.

The voting rights of the Members shall be in proportion of their shareholding to the total paid-up equity share capital of the Bank as on the cut-off date, i.e., **Friday, March 13, 2026**.

INSTRUCTIONS FOR REMOTE E-VOTING:

Detailed instructions for remote e-Voting are provided in **Note No. 18** of the Postal Ballot Notice.

Kindly note that once Members cast their votes on the resolutions, the same cannot be modified subsequently.

RESULT OF POSTAL BALLOT:

The Board of Directors of the Bank has appointed **Ms. Manisha Maheshwari**, Practicing Company Secretary [**Membership No. FCS: 13272 and CP: 11031**], Partner of M/s. Bhandari & Associates, Company Secretaries or failing her, **Mr. Saurabh Somani**, Practicing Company Secretary [**Membership No. ACS: 69826 and CP: 26495**], Partner of M/s. Bhandari & Associates, Company Secretaries, as the Scrutinizer for conducting the Postal Ballot e-Voting process in a fair and transparent manner and in accordance with the provisions of the Companies Act and the rules made thereunder.

The Scrutinizer, on completion of scrutiny of the votes cast through remote e-Voting, shall submit the report to the Chairperson of the Bank or a person authorized by him, who will announce the results of such e-Voting latest by **Tuesday, April 21, 2026**, in accordance with the applicable provisions of law.

The results declared, along with the Scrutinizer's Report, shall be placed on the website of the Bank at www.idfcfirst.bank.in, on the website of NSDL at www.evoting.nsdl.com and shall also be simultaneously communicated to the BSE and the NSE.

In case of any queries, you may refer the Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs) for Shareholders and e-Voting user manual for Shareholders available at the download section of www.evoting.nsdl.com or call on: 022 - 4886 7000 or send a request to Ms. Pallavi Mhatre at evoting@nsdl.com

By order of the Board of Directors of

IDFC FIRST Bank Limited

Sd/-

Satish Gaikwad

General Counsel and

Company Secretary

Place: Mumbai
Date: March 18, 2026

Course correction

The overvalued Indian market is facing a reality check

Indian markets have fallen sharply since the start of the US-Israel-Iran war; they have reacted to the disruption in supply of critical energy sources, and to crude breaching \$100 per barrel. The benchmark Nifty50 index has lost around 7 per cent since the war began three weeks ago, akin to other global emerging market benchmarks. However, this fall may actually be beneficial to the long-term health of our markets.



Stocks from many sectors were unhinged from fundamentals. Retail investors who entered stock markets in large numbers post Covid, propelled a surge in demand for direct and indirect equity (through the mutual fund route). As a result, Indian stocks have been quite pricey, compared to other emerging markets. The Nifty50 traded at price-earnings multiple of 21.7 times towards the end of 2025. This was at a premium to benchmark indices of other EMs including China, South Korea, Brazil and South Africa which traded at PE multiples between 11 and 18. Stocks in consumption-oriented sectors such as FMCG, healthcare and retail trade traded at higher PE multiples of over 50 times. The absence of a deep correction since the Covid-low in March 2020, with declines not exceeding 20 per cent from the peak, had led to complacency with investors buying at every dip. Stocks remained elevated for too long. Owing to these higher valuations, foreign portfolio investors turned net sellers of India equity since September 2024, pulling out close to ₹3.5 lakh crore. The ongoing correction will help valuations to revert to their mean levels. The valuation of Nifty50 has cooled a bit, with the PE multiple declining to 19.51 times. But prices need to decline further.

And they well may. Given the multiple headwinds currently facing markets and the economy, investors should be prepared for further price corrections. If the war in West Asia prolongs, corporate margins are going to shrink, as fuel, logistics and input costs increase. Shortage of LPG and other fuel will likely further dent corporate bottomlines. The domestic economy, which was trotting along nicely before the onset of this war, is up against multiple first and second-order effects. Besides shocks in the form of prices, supplies and asset valuations, the sentiment factor, too, could hurt business. It does not help that there are just a few stocks in nascent, sought-after sectors such as AI and semiconductors.

The bottomline is that market corrections should happen when the underlying fundamentals change. After all, equities are not meant to be risk-free, and excesses created in bull and bear markets need to be ironed out. The Securities and Exchange Board of India should let markets follow their course, while watching out for any undue volatility caused by manipulation. The regulator, Association of Mutual Funds in India and other investor bodies should run awareness campaigns, advising investors to pursue long-term goals with realistic expectations.

OTHER VOICES.

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.
EUROPE

Why the SAVE America Act . . . Won't
For partisan hype, it's hard to beat the Senate debate this week on the SAVE America Act. President Trump says the legislation is a salvation from mass voter fraud. Sen. Chuck Schumer says it's an effort at mass voter suppression, "Jim Crow 2.0." Neither is reality. Also, Republicans don't have the votes to clear the Senate's filibuster. And if they bully the bill through anyway, Democrats eyeing the end of the 60-vote rule will quietly celebrate. The House version of the SAVE America Act has two main planks. First, people registering to vote would be asked to show proof of US citizenship, such as a passport, birth certificate or naturalization document. Many driver's licenses wouldn't qualify. While the bill says it would accept a REAL ID "that indicates the applicant is a citizen," standard license designs often don't say. (NEW YORK, MARCH 17)

GULF NEWS
15th ANNIVERSARY

The challenges facing World Cup 2026
When the expanded 48-team FIFA World Cup kicks off in North America on June 11, 2026, it will be the largest sporting event ever staged. Matches will take place across the United States, Canada, and Mexico, involving millions of spectators and a global television audience expected to exceed five billion. The tournament is now unfolding against a geopolitical backdrop that few planners anticipated: a major war in the Middle East involving the United States and Israel against Iran, and an increasingly assertive foreign policy under the current US administration. Many quietly hope that the conflict will de-escalate or conclude well before the tournament begins, as a prolonged war would risk casting a shadow over the world's largest sporting event. (DUBAI, MARCH 17)



P. ELANGO
My favourite management lesson used to be this: when cow gets into the ditch (which often happens when you run an oil and gas company), one has to first get the cow out of the ditch, figure out how it got there and then ensure it does not get there. These three common sense steps need to be taken sequentially and not simultaneously. Let's follow the same principle while analysing the "worrisome" scenario, as the government put it, in LPG supply. The government is taking a series of measures including allocating priority for LPG usage, tightening the booking cycle, invoking the Essential Commodities Act to increase domestic production of LPG, securing safe passage for Indian flagged vessels to pass through the Strait of Hormuz and diversifying the LPG supply by sourcing from the US. To know how we got into the current LPG situation requires understanding of some basics. A balanced mix of propane and butane is commonly known as liquefied petroleum gas (LPG). And it is produced in the process of converting crude oil into petroleum products such as petrol and diesel in the refineries. India has surplus refining capacity and was able to export about 65 million tonnes (mt) of petroleum products last year.

LARGE-SCALE IMPORTS
However, India imports 60 per cent of its LPG requirement and 90 per cent of that is from the Middle East, which means the vessels carrying the consignments have to necessarily pass through the Hormuz bottleneck. The first question is: when we have surplus refining capacity, why do we have to import LPG? LPG production is highest (3-5 per cent) from light and sweet crude oil, but the Indian basket of crude (all the different types of crude that the country imports) has only 20 per cent light crude, as it is more expensive in international markets. Eighty per cent of crude that India imports consist of medium to heavy sour crude which are traded at a discount. However, modern Indian refineries with high complexity index are able to crack the heavy oil into export grade petroleum products. This process has some built in flexibility and that is how Indian refineries are able to increase the LPG production under the current emergency protocol. Still this will not be sufficient as India consumes about 60 lakh LPG cylinders



everyday, the largest in the world for household cooking. LPG coverage, post the successful PM Ujala Yojana, is more than 10 crore households. Other countries do not depend solely on LPG as cooking fuel; electric or piped gas cooking is more common. So in the current geopolitical conflict India has a unique problem to deal with. In a way the current situation is similar to the oxygen shortage that hospitals across the country faced during the coronavirus pandemic. India has no facilities for strategic storage of LPG reserves to meet a crisis, and the commercial storage the oil companies together hold can meet only less than 15 days of normal consumption. The cost of storing LPG isn't much when compared to the economic cost of shortage, perceived or real. The investment needed to create storage to meet one day's requirement is about ₹2,000 crore. Surface storage

As part of a robust energy security plan, we should have built a buffer of 45 days of surface and sub-surface storage (strategic and commercial) capacity

capacity can be custom built for large customer segments, and large sub-surface strategic storage capacity can be created in suitable caverns to meet crisis situations such as the current one.

SKEWED SOURCING
In the energy security planning agenda, LPG seems to have missed its rightful place. And we ended up sourcing nearly all our LPG imports from the Middle East. The major alternative source is the US, which is the largest producer and exporter of LPG in the world and it hardly uses LPG as a cooking fuel. However the transit time will be about 45 days, as the vessels have to take a longer route to avoid the strait of Hormuz. As part of a robust energy security plan, we should have thought through this scenario and built a buffer of 45 days of surface and sub-surface storage (strategic and commercial) capacity. It's better late than never, and planning should start at least now if we are to avoid a "cylinder in a ditch" situation. Piped natural gas (PNG), compressed natural gas (CNG) and LNG are different modes of storing and transporting natural gas, which is produced directly from gas fields in Mumbai High, Krishna-Godavari offshore and in onshore fields of

Gujarat, Rajasthan and Assam either along with oil as associated gas or independently as natural gas. The gas being predominantly methane, its storage will require expensive liquefaction and re-gasification process or reinjection in reservoirs. Though LPG and natural gas can meet the same purpose, they are produced through different methods and by different entities. LPG is produced by downstream oil companies such as IOC, BPCL and HOCL in the public sector, and Reliance and Nayara Energy in the private sector. Natural gas is produced by upstream players such as ONGC, OIL and a few independent oil companies in the private sector. Incidentally, India meets about 50 per cent of its natural gas requirements by importing LNG. Disruption in LNG imports has implications for the industrial sector, too. Policy planners must give serious thought to electric cooking as an alternative option. Though it would be expensive, at least we will not be dependent on any other country. Ten crore households depending on imported fuel to cook their daily meal is no way to build national energy security.

The writer is former CEO, Cairn India, and former MD, HOEC

Keep alcohol, tobacco out of low-duty trade deals

Trade policy cannot trump the Constitution. The gains from tariff cuts are washed away by costs to health, family and society

Dileep Mavalankar
Abhay Bang

As India steps up its global trade talks (bilateral free trade pacts or broader arrangements), there is a temptation to treat all commodities as equal bargaining chips. The discourse revolves around market access, tariff reductions and investor confidence. Yet there is one line that India must not cross: allowing foreign alcohol and tobacco products to enter the country at low customs duties. This is not merely a question of economics or protectionism. It is a constitutional, moral, and public health imperative. The Constitution is unambiguous on the role of the State in relation to intoxicating and harmful substances. Article 47, one of the Directive Principles of State Policy, explicitly directs the State to "endeavour to bring about prohibition of the consumption except for medicinal purposes of intoxicating drinks and of drugs which are injurious to health." While Directive Principles are not justiciable, they are fundamental to the governance of the country and serve as guiding principles for any state policy. Trade negotiations, conducted in the name of national interest, cannot be exempt from this

constitutional responsibility. Alcohol and tobacco are not ordinary consumer goods. Rather, they are among the important causes of preventable death and disease in India. Their harmfulness ranges from cancers, cardiovascular diseases, liver disorders, road traffic injuries, domestic violence, and loss of productivity. The WHO estimates, 40 million Indians are alcohol addicts. US Surgeon General has proposed a mandatory label on alcoholic beverages that alcohol causes seven types of cancers.

HEALTH HAZARDS
The Lancet and the WHO now unequivocally state that only safe limit of drinking alcohol is zero drinking. Gujarat, Bihar, Nagaland and Mizoram have prohibition in place. Meanwhile, tobacco alone kills more than a million Indians each year, while alcohol use imposes enormous social and economic costs on families, particularly among the poor and women and children. Any policy that makes these products cheaper, more accessible, or more socially acceptable contradicts the State's constitutional duty to protect public health and life and liberty of citizens. When customs duties on imported liquor and tobacco are slashed as part of



LIQUOR. No safe consumption limit

trade deals, foreign brands become more affordable, more aggressively marketed — especially to youth. Global experience shows that transnational alcohol and tobacco corporations are very skilled at exploiting new markets with weak regulation. When India agrees to lower tariffs on whisky, wine, cigarettes, or novel tobacco products, it sends a clear signal that revenue and trade relations matter more than health, social welfare, and even the Constitution. This goes against government's campaigns to reduce use of tobacco and alcohol. Trade negotiators often count tariff reductions as "wins" without accounting for the downstream fiscal and social costs borne by health systems, families, and society. True economic rationality demands a

full accounting — not just of trade flows. Public health exceptions under World Trade Organization rules and many bilateral agreements allow countries to restrict trade in products harmful to health. India, with its explicit constitutional directive, has an even stronger moral and legal basis to exclude alcohol and tobacco from low tariff treatment. What India needs, therefore, is a clear red line in trade policy: alcohol and tobacco products must be removed from tariff-reduction commitments. Just as India has taken principled positions on access to medicines, generic drugs, and public health safeguards, it must now do the same for alcohol and tobacco. India has taken a tough stand on agri and dairy products as well. At a time when non-communicable diseases are rising, healthcare systems are under strain, and families are grappling with the social fallout of addiction, trade policy cannot afford to be blind to its consequences. The long-term national interest requires the courage to say no to alcohol and tobacco in trade negotiations.

Dileep is public health expert and former director of Indian Institute of Public Health, Gandhinagar, and Bang is Director of SEARCH Gadchiroli and a public health expert and activist for tribal health

✉ **LETTERS TO EDITOR** Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to 'Letters to the Editor', The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

Luxury cars in demand
Apropos 'FTAs set to drive luxury car market: Audi India' (March 18). Many Indians aspire to own luxury cars despite crowded streets and pothole-ridden roads. High-speed driving is rarely possible, yet comfort, smooth suspension, and stylish interiors make the ride enjoyable. For most buyers, the appeal lies less in utility and more in prestige and display of wealth. Free Trade Agreements (FTAs) could lower prices, encouraging wider adoption. Still, the pride of ownership often outweighs practical challenges. However, Indian roads remain unsuitable for such vehicles. The first priority should be building infrastructure fit for luxury cars before expanding imports or

manufacturing them locally. **O Prasada Rao** Hyderabad **Uplift of rural areas** This is with reference to 'Rapidly developing Naidupeta emerges as a key industrial node in southern AP' (March 18). If India has to achieve all-round growth and development the contribution of the rural economy is vital. Due to lack of employment opportunities in rural areas people migrate to urban areas resulting in over-congestion of urban areas and all the problems relating to migration. To arrest this, it is important to start industries in rural areas. In this background it is refreshing to read about industrial development in Naidupeta, a small

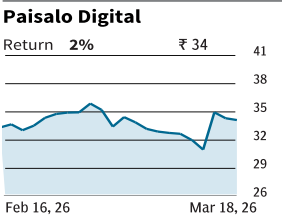
town in Tirupati district. Investments in infrastructure projects in rural and semi-urban areas will go a long way in creating employment opportunities for the youth in villages. **Veena Shenoy** Thane **Pulling up insurers** This refers to 'Wrongdoing by insurance cos will not go unnoticed' (March 18). That the list of those subjected to penalties for various misdeeds, reads like a veritable who is who of Indian insurance industry, is not a matter of solace. It is proof of the extent of malfeasance unbecoming of institutions entrusted with fiduciary responsibility and trust. Collecting

hefty sums as fines does not equate with good governance. Proactive monitoring, timely enforcement, are the abysmally lacking in Indian insurance, evidenced by reactionary fines. High time, the authorities thrash out the pain points in designing plans with adequate insurance cover for all, at affordable rates and on practical conditions. **Jose Abraham** Vaikom, Kerala **Stabilisation fund** Apropos 'Scenario planning' (March 18), government's decision to institute an Economic Stabilisation Fund constitutes a judicious and forward-looking policy intervention amid escalating geopolitical tensions in West Asia. With crude price

fluctuations exerting inflationary pressures and straining fiscal balances, such a mechanism assumes critical importance. By creating a financial buffer to absorb external shocks, the fund can facilitate price moderation, macroeconomic stability, and policy flexibility during periods of uncertainty. It also reflects a calibrated approach to economic governance in an increasingly unpredictable global landscape. If operationalised efficiently, this initiative could significantly bolster India's resilience, ensuring sustained growth while mitigating the spillovers of energy-driven disruptions. **N Sadasiva Reddy** Bengaluru

QUICKLY.

Paisalo Digital-proposed NCD gets AA rating



New Delhi: NBFC firm Paisalo Digital on Wednesday said its proposed ₹1,500 crore non-convertible debenture (NCD) has received 'AA/Stable' rating from Brickwork Ratings. The rating agency has assigned a long-term rating of "BWR AA/Stable" for the company's proposed ₹1,500 crore NCD issuance, supplementing the company's existing rating from Infomeric Analytics and Research, Paisalo Digital said in a statement. This dual rating reflects Paisalo's continued commitment to transparency, strong governance standards and broader investor participation in its debt capital market issuances, it added.

Axis Bank to infuse ₹1,500 cr into Axis Finance

Mumbai: Axis Bank's board committee on Wednesday approved infusing ₹1,500 crore into its wholly-owned subsidiary Axis Finance (AFL) through a rights issue, in one or more tranches, by March 31, 2027. The investment, cleared by the RBI on March 10, 2026, is intended to provide growth capital to the non-banking financial company. Axis Bank's shareholding in AFL will remain at 100 per cent both before and after the investment. AFL, incorporated on April 27, 1995, has posted consistent revenue growth over the past three years — ₹2,297 crore in FY23, ₹3,321 crore in FY24 and ₹4,296 crore in FY25. Its turnover for the first half of FY26 stood at ₹2,504 crore.

Edelweiss AMC launches passive hybrid fund NFO

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

Edelweiss Asset Management Company has launched the first-ever hybrid passive index fund that invests in the Edelweiss Nifty LargeMid-cap250 and 8-13 year G-Sec 70:30 Index Fund. The new fund offer (NFO) opened for subscription on Wednesday. The open-ended index scheme allocates 70 per cent to equities and 30 per cent to government securities. The equity component tracks the Nifty LargeMid-cap250 Index, while the debt portion tracks the Nifty 8-13 year G-Sec Index, creating a portfolio that combines broad equity exposure with the relative stability of sovereign bonds. Hybrid passive funds have recently become possible following regulatory approvals and the development of eligible debt indices that meet the required market depth and scale.

FIRST IN INDIA
Radhika Gupta, MD and CEO, Edelweiss AMC, said the first

GSP Crop IPO subscribed 1.6x

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

The IPO of agrochemical maker GSP Crop Science attracted investor interest on the final day of bidding, with the initial public offering fetching an overall subscription of 1.61 times. The ₹400-crore public issue received healthy participation from institutional and high-net-worth investors. The qualified institutional buyers' portion was booked 2.66 times, while the non-institutional investor segment saw robust demand with 3.05 times subscription. Retail participation remained subdued, with the segment subscribed 0.4 times. Of the proceeds from the fresh issue, ₹170 crore will be used for debt repayment and the rest for general corporate purposes.

Ignoring Re noise, equity gains for 3rd day in 'stabilisation' phase amid caution

WIDESPREAD RALLY. IT stocks led the pack while auto and broader markets also saw strong participation

Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai

The markets are headed into a stabilisation phase with a cautiously bullish undertone, even as the rupee crashed to a fresh record low and geopolitical tensions over West Asia continued to cloud the outlook. That is the broad consensus from analysts after Dalal Street closed higher for a third consecutive session on Wednesday, with the Nifty 50 rising 196.65 points to settle at 23,777.80 and the BSE Sensex climbing 633 points to close at 76,704. The Nifty Midcap100 gained 2 per cent and the Smallcap100 rose 1.6 per cent.

Vinod Nair, Head-Re-

search, Geojit Investments, said, "In the near term, the market is expected to remain volatile with a mixed bias. Positivity is driven by short covering and value buying, while scepticism stems from uncertainties surrounding the heightened disruptive phase of the West Asia war. At the same time, downside risks appear contained, as deep value has emerged following the sell-off, and the FY27 outlook continues to remain stable."

Positive global cues also boosted the sentiment. US markets closed higher overnight, Asian markets held firm through the day and European bourses opened positively.

VOLATILITY SLIDES
The India VIX fell 3.3 per



IN REVERSE GEAR. IT stocks ended up on easing concerns over AI disruption, led by Tech Mahindra and HCL Tech

cent, signalling a reduction in near-term fear, though analysts cautioned that volatility is likely to persist. Aakash Shah, Technical Analyst, Choice Equity Broking, said the market is "transitioning into a stabilisation phase with a positive under-

tone, rather than a sharp directional rally." The BSE clocked 3,202 advances against 1,088 declines.

NIFTY IT INDEX UP
Jio Financial was the top Nifty gainer, surging 4.59 per cent, followed by Eternal

(3.46 per cent), Tech Mahindra (3.05 per cent), HCL Tech (2.79 per cent) and Infosys (2.74 per cent). The Nifty IT index rose over 4 per cent. Siddhartha Khemka, Head of Research at Motilal Oswal Financial Services, pointed out that IT stocks were "further supported by easing concerns around AI disruption" while the auto sector, which had fallen 9.1 per cent in March, also recovered, with the auto index gaining over 2 per cent, backed by "strong auto registrations in March". Markets will next track developments in West Asia and crude oil movements, alongside the US Federal Reserve's interest rate decision and progress on the India-US trade agreement.

BSE launches 2 Long-Short Indices, 2 Inverse Indices for hedging strategies

Our Bureau
Mumbai

BSE Index Services, a wholly-owned subsidiary of the BSE, on Wednesday launched four new indices — two Long-Short Indices and two Inverse Indices — to offer systematic hedging tools to asset managers and investors. The two Long-Short indices follow an 80:20 allocation framework, combining 80 per cent long exposure in the BSE 500 with a 20 per cent inverse position in either the BSE 200 or the BSE 150 MidCap index. The two Inverse indices — BSE 200 1X Inverse Daily and BSE 150 MidCap 1X Inverse Daily — track the inverse returns of their respective underlying total return indices on a daily basis.

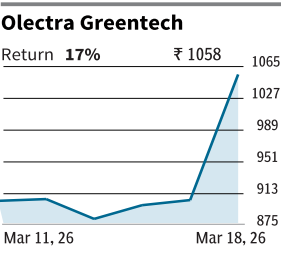


BENCHMARKING SIFs
Ashutosh Singh, MD & CEO, BSE Index Services, said the indices were designed to support rule-based long-short strategies and help asset managers build more resilient product offerings as markets grow increasingly dynamic. They are intended primarily for benchmarking Specialised Investment Funds (SIFs). BSE Index Services, formerly Asia Index, calculates and maintains a broad family of indices for domestic and global investors.

EV stocks on top gear as oil price remains firm on West Asia crisis

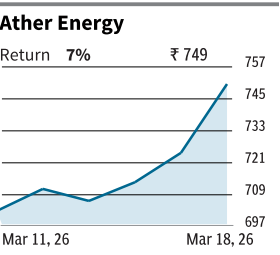
Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Electric vehicle-related stocks JBM Auto, Ather Energy, Ola Electric Mobility and Olectra Greentech rallied sharply on Wednesday, defying broader weakness in the market as investors bet that persistently high crude oil prices could accelerate the shift toward electric mobility. JBM Auto settled 19 per cent higher at ₹585.30 on the BSE. Olectra rallied over 17 per cent to ₹1058.15. Ather Energy and Ola Electric settled 4-5 per cent positive.



Investors anticipate that rising fuel costs amid the West Asia conflict will accelerate consumer demand for electric vehicles as buyers increasingly look for cost-efficient alternatives to petrol and diesel transportation.

INVESTOR CONFIDENCE
At the same time, expecta-



tions of a targeted government push to reduce oil dependence are strengthening confidence in the sector's long-term prospects. Meanwhile, the auto sector witnessed pressure recently due to heightened fears of natural gas supply disruption, fuel availability and rising cost pressures.

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) has levied penalties totalling ₹2.8 crore on 18 entities for allegedly manipulating the share prices of Retro Green Revolution (RGRL). The regulator directed Sanjay Arunkumar Choksi and Western Agrotech Innovative to disgorge unlawful gains of ₹2.94 crore, along with 12 per cent interest, from December 31, 2021, till the date of payment. The amount is to be deposited in SEBI's Investor Pro-

tection and Education Fund within 45 days. It also barred the 18 entities from the securities market for up to five years. The investigation found that the entities were part of a premeditated scheme to artificially increase the price of the illiquid scrip of RGRL and lure investors. **MODUS OPERANDI** The scheme involved trading among connected entities to create artificial volumes in a thin stock, followed by circulating tips/stock recommendations through a Telegram channel. The entities had indulged



in creating a misleading appearance of trading in the scrip and manipulated the price. "I find that noticee no 1 (Choksi) did not act in good faith and exploited his influence in the company for personal gains. The rise in volume of shares in the other-

wise illiquid scrip of RGRL and the Telegram recommendation are indicators affecting the investment decision that sway the investors in trading in the scrip," SEBI's Quasi-Judicial Authority Santosh Shukla said in the order. The entities allowed certain entities to offload illiquid shares of RGRL to general public investors, thereby earning unlawful gains of a little over ₹2.94 crore. Each entity has been fined in the range of ₹5-50 lakh. The investigation was conducted for the period from September 1, 2020, till December 31, 2021.

BROKER'S CALL.

Motilal Oswal Research

SBI LIFE INSURANCE (BUY)
Target: ₹2,400
CMP: ₹1,961.90
SBI Life Insurance has been a consistent compounder with FY20-25 APE CAGR at 15 per cent vs. 6 per cent for the industry, supported by an extensive SBI branch network and one of the largest agent bases in the private life insurance industry. We expect the growth trajectory to remain stable at about 15 per cent for FY26-28 as well. The company is gradually shifting its mix toward higher-margin traditional products, aiming to reduce ULIP share in individual APE from about 67 per cent currently to about 60 per cent. The company is targeting to increase the share of Protection to 9-9.5 per cent of individual APE. The management expects the APE growth trajectory to further improve from about 15 per cent, as the product mix shifts towards traditional products. The gradual shift toward higher-margin products, robust operational efficiency and rising rider attachments is expected to help maintain VNB margin at 26-28 per cent, despite temporary headwinds from the loss of input tax credit. The potential implementation of commission caps is expected to cause low impact for SBI Life, given its commission ratio (about 4.8 per cent in 9MFY26) is significantly better than the industry average. The combination of sustained APE growth, stable VNB margins and disciplined cost management positions SBI Life to achieve about 18 per cent operating RoEV, going forward. We reiterate our Buy rating with a TP of ₹2,400 (based on 2.1x FY28E P/EV).

Geojit Retail Equity Research

PRESTIGE ESTATES PROJECTS (BUY)
Target: ₹1,623
CMP: ₹1,320.30
Prestige Estates Projects' expansion is driven by a diverse portfolio, covering residential, office, retail and hospitality segments. In 9MFY26, pre-sales surged 122 per cent year on year, surpassing the previous full-year peak, driven primarily by a strong 40 per cent contribution from the NCR region. Quarterly sales volumes stood at 2.9 million sq ft, with over 8,500 units sold YTD, alongside a 6 per cent increase in average realisations. Revenue for Q3 grew 128 per cent, driven by strong project completions. However, EBITDA margin for the quarter stood at 22.5 per cent (vs. 34.3 per cent for 9M), with Q3 compression attributable to product mix. The management has raised its FY26 pre-sales guidance to over ₹30,000 crore, having already achieved ₹22,327 crore in the first nine months, keeping it firmly on track to meet its FY26 guidance. A strong Q4 launch pipeline across key markets such as Bengaluru, Hyderabad and Chennai, coupled with unrecognised revenue of ₹61,922 crore, provides healthy visibility on future bookings and revenue realisation. However, margins continue to face pressure due to an adverse product mix and elevated business development spending. Despite these near-term challenges, current valuations appear reasonable. Hence, we upgrade our rating to Buy, with a revised target price of ₹1,623, based on FY28E NAV.

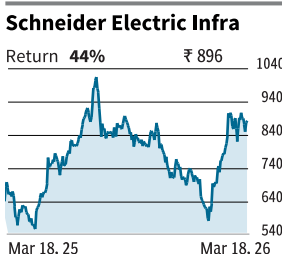
businessline is not responsible for the recommendations sourced from third party brokerages. Reports may be sent to: blmarketwatch@gmail.com

TODAY'S PICK.

Schneider Electric Infra (₹896.85): BUY

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl_research_bureau

The stock of Schneider Electric Infrastructure has been oscillating in a sideways trend over the past month. It is now stuck within ₹840 and ₹930. Prior to that, it saw a sharp uptrend, which began in January on the back of the support at ₹575. So, the broader trend remains positive despite the recent sideways crawl. We expect the stock to begin the next leg of uptrend anytime soon. Once it begins, the price is likely to see a rise to ₹1,200. Therefore, participants can buy the stock now at ₹896 and



accumulate at ₹850. Place initial stop-loss at ₹800. When price touches ₹1,000 and ₹1,100, move the stop-loss up to ₹900 and ₹1,040 respectively. Book profits at ₹1,200. Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

Day trading guide

23774 » Nifty 50 Futures

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
23530	23350	23900	24000	Trading near a resistance band; short with stop-loss at 23950.

₹843 » HDFC Bank

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
832	812	850	870	Go long if the stock surpasses 850; place stop-loss at 838.

₹1267 » Infosys

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1250	1225	1290	1320	Buy the stock if it bounces off 1250; stop-loss can be 1225.

₹304 » ITC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
302	296	307	310	Short the stock if it falls below 302; stop-loss can be 307.

₹264 » ONGC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
262	259	267	272	Stock is hovering near a resistance; sell with stop-loss at 267.

₹1408 » Reliance Ind.

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1395	1370	1415	1435	Intraday trend is uncertain for the stock; hence stay away.

₹1070 » SBI

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1042	1030	1076	1100	Stock is trading near a barrier; go short with stop-loss at 1085.

₹2441 » TCS

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
2410	2370	2480	2550	Buy the stock if it bounces off 2410; stop-loss can be 2370.

S1, S2: Support 1 & 2; R1, R2: Resistance 1 & 2.

Nifty 50 Movers

	Close(₹)	Pts	PE	WN(%)
Infosys	1267.10	26.28	18.35	4.09
Bharti Airtel	1855.40	17.36	28.55	4.77
M&M	3214.60	16.78	23.65	2.65
L&T	3607.90	16.77	26.15	3.91
Avis Bank	1253.20	15.78	14.73	3.31
Reliance Ind	1408.10	15.55	19.49	8.77
Eternal Ltd.	242.54	12.47	1013.25	1.61
TCS	2440.80	11.00	18.41	2.30
HCL Tech	1357.20	8.36	22.36	1.32
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	246.25	7.62	98.26	0.75
Bajaj Finance	880.10	6.70	29.89	2.16
Tech Mahindra	1385.20	6.04	29.56	0.81
Adani Ports	1401.90	5.89	25.85	0.95
Shriram Finance Ltd.	1021.60	5.22	21.01	1.32
Titan	4145.50	4.98	77.22	1.58
State Bank	1069.80	4.64	11.41	4.10
Bajaj Auto	9271.00	3.92	29.14	0.95
Int'l Globevii	4360.60	3.61	52.50	0.91
Eicher Motors	7027.50	3.55	35.98	0.88
UltraTech Cement	11247.00	3.41	43.25	1.23
Grasim Ind	2723.10	3.34	19.57	0.96
SBI Life	1962.50	2.99	79.38	0.81
SJS Steel	1180.30	2.70	37.17	1.20
Bharat Elec	442.60	2.55	54.26	1.46
Tata Motors PV	324.75	2.55	44.16	0.63
Asian Paints	2262.10	2.37	55.49	0.94
Maruti Suzuki	13048.00	2.19	27.47	1.58
Bajaj Finserv	1791.80	2.15	14.91	0.95
Kotak Bank	375.40	1.94	19.86	2.55
Wipro	194.30	1.87	15.38	0.51
Adani Enter	2007.20	1.82	16.39	0.48
Dr Reddys Lab	1294.80	1.47	19.57	0.73
ICIICI Bank	1299.30	0.94	16.28	0.85
PowerGrid Corp	289.40	0.89	17.94	1.25
Max Healthcare	979.80	0.55	67.16	0.67
Trent Ltd.	365.70	0.52	73.90	0.27
HDFC Life	643.35	0.25	73.44	0.64
ONGC	265.00	0.21	7.41	0.95
Tata Steel	195.41	-0.04	26.74	1.49
NestleIndia	1204.80	-0.33	71.23	0.80
DataConsumerProduct	1075.10	-0.41	72.30	0.65
Apollo Hosp	7471.00	-0.85	57.57	0.71
Hindalco	933.05	-1.14	13.04	1.25
Cipla	1268.50	-1.65	22.60	0.66
ITC	304.05	-1.69	18.40	2.70
Coal India	455.20	-3.51	9.43	0.95
Sun Pharma	1778.30	-3.74	38.96	1.74
Hind Unilever	2135.30	-4.46	49.90	1.75
WIPAC	378.50	-5.04	14.78	3.17
HDFC Bank	843.05	-7.72	16.75	11.90

Pts: Impact on index movement

Nifty Next 50 Movers

Power Finance	432.25	62.03	4.27	2.88
Tvs Motor Cmp	3572.80	59.92	55.59	3.83
Indian Hotels Co.	366.95	39.26	41.89	2.56
Rural Elec	348.05	38.78	5.32	1.99
Adani Energy Solutions	1036.70	37.57	52.24	1.64
Info Edge I	994.90	37.07	38.29	1.77
Varun Beverages	415.10	35.93	45.85	2.60
Ltimindtree	4298.80	30.49	26.98	1.82
Dif	563.10	29.45	31.48	1.65
AvenueSuper	3844.00	27.66	87.33	2.59
Gail (India)	150.95	26.22	11.53	1.86
SamvardhoreInternat	117.78	25.98	34.16	2.39
Pidlittind	1384.40	25.53	60.88	1.96
Bajaj Holdings	9859.00	25.46	12.24	1.95
Jindal Steel	1179.20	24.55	59.67	2.01
Magadan Dock	2456.90	21.56	41.18	0.85
Bpd	303.70	21.23	5.35	2.60
AdaniGreenenergy	891.30	20.83	79.10	1.25
Divis Lab	6140.00	20.39	65.75	3.56
Havells	1343.90	20.28	56.85	1.55
Siemens Energy India	2840.60	19.03	85.63	1.15
Indian Oilcorp	148.27	17.82	5.68	2.53
United Spirits	1320.30	16.75	55.83	1.78
Godrej Consumer	1053.80	15.33	59.19	1.94
Ambuja Cements	441.25	12.90	22.16	1.23
Siemens	3220.90	12.57	72.34	1.30
Punjab Natl Bank	113.12	11.59	7.27	1.78
MacroTech Developers	854.15	10.09	25.50	1.10
Shree Cement	2325.00	10.03	48.06	1.46
Britannia Ind	5885.00	9.73	58.66	3.17
Canara Bank	137.51	9.41	6.77	2.12
Bosch	31005.00	9.37	33.17	1.23
Hyundai Motor India	1990.40	8.21	27.93	1.30
Indian Railway Finance Corp	98.25	8.09	18.32	0.80
ZydusIntellisciences	899.60	7.36	18.01	1.03
Lic	785.85	5.39	9.37	0.80
Jsw Energy	509.10	5.31	34.18	1.25
Bajaj Housing Finance	83.09	5.03	27.94	0.94
Abb India	6337.50	4.25	79.64	1.52
Bank of Baroda	283.15	-0.56	7.45	2.40
Hindustanaeronautics	3961.60	-0.85	29.78	3.43
T				
Power & I Sol	700.35	-2.52	25.58	3.07
Liombard Group	1821.20	-3.34	33.34	2.03
Pharmax	5528.20	-5.08	10.78	2.54
industandlamini&Fin	1383.20	-6.09	26.54	2.95
Indus Zinc	53.67	-11.38	19.25	1.06
Iranliani Power	1547.07	-18.11	26.30	2.78
Nar Industries	13699.00	-24.48	81.20	1.52
adanta	679.00	-103.58	16.02	5.26

‘Shift to natural farming shows no yield loss, gains seen in some cases’

ORGANIC PUSH. Govt has urged farmers to allocate 20 per cent of their land to natural farming

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

Informing Parliament that around 18 lakh farmers have registered to practise natural farming across more than eight lakh hectares, Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan stated on Wednesday that scientific evidence confirms there is no drop in yield when transitioning to chemical-free methods.

In some instances, productivity actually rises, he noted.

Replying to a Lok Sabha discussion on the Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare’s demand for grants, Chouhan explained that the government had urged farmers to allocate 20 per cent of



Union Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan in the Lok Sabha

their land, rather than their entire holdings, to natural farming. “Many MPs have expressed concerns over soil degradation and declining production capacity due to the excessive and imbalanced use of chemical fertilizers. Our government has launched the National Natural Farming Mission to ensure soil productivity is preserved... We advised farmers with five acres to dedicate

just one acre to natural farming,” Chouhan said.

“I state with full responsibility that if natural farming is practised correctly, productivity does not fall, and in some cases, yields even increase, a fact proven by scientists,” he added, noting that the government intends to transition the country gradually to protect the “health of Mother Earth.”

However, he did not ad-

dress several issues raised by MPs across party lines, focusing instead on the NDA government’s achievements since 2014 in comparison to the UPA’s tenure.

ISSUES RAISED

Major demands highlighted by MPs included increasing the PM-Kisan fiscal incentive from the current ₹6,000 per year, enacting a legal MSP guarantee and fixing the MSP using the Swaminathan Commission’s C2+50 per cent formula.

Some MPs also requested that the government table the details of the US trade agreement referenced in a recent joint statement. In response, Chouhan blamed the UPA government for refusing to set MSP based on the A2+Family Labour formula,

asserting that the NDA government decided in 2018 to fix MSP at a minimum of 50 per cent profit over production costs. He stressed that minor financial aid of ₹500 or ₹1,000 cannot fully resolve farmers’ challenges.

The fundamental issue, he argued, lay in ensuring the quality of seeds, fertilizers and pesticides. To this end, the government will soon introduce a new Pesticide Act and a new Seed Act, aimed at guaranteeing high-quality inputs and safe, effective pesticides.

Citing the recent Budget, Chouhan highlighted ‘Bharat Vistaar,’ an AI-powered platform that allows farmers to receive expert agricultural advice by calling a helpline or uploading photos of their crops directly from the field.

London HC reserves judgment over fugitive Nirav Modi’s extradition plea

Our Bureau
New Delhi



Nirav Modi

Fugitive diamond merchant Nirav Modi’s plea to reopen his extradition case has concluded with the High Court in London reserving its judgment on Tuesday.

The billionaire jeweller, who escaped from India in January 2018, is relying heavily on fugitive arms dealer Sanjay Bhandari and is using the fear of human rights violation in his application before the London High Court to wriggle out of India’s legal fight to get him back for trial in criminal cases.

The London High Court had turned down the Indian government’s request seeking permission to appeal in the Supreme Court against the discharge of Bhandari in a money laundering case and tax evasion cases.

Similarly, Modi’s lawyers expressed fear in their argu-

ment before Lord Jeremy Stuart-Smith and Justice Robert Jay that their client faced a “real risk of torture” during interrogation by the investigating agencies in India, agency reports said.

IMPORTANT CASE

“This case is of extreme importance to Modi and to the Indian officials who have travelled from India. We will deliver the judgment as soon as possible,” said Stuart-Smith.

Modi, 54, virtually appeared via video link from Pentonville prison in north London in the \$2 billion Punjab National Bank (PNB) loan scam case.

The Crown Prosecution Service (CPS), which represented the Indian government in court, challenged Modi’s grounds — mainly that there is a real risk of inhuman or degrading treatment or torture arising from interrogation — for reopening the matter to scuttle his extradition ordered nearly six years ago.

His lawyer countered assurances given by the Government of India to downplay the risk raised over the prospect of additional non-bailable warrants being executed against the diamantaire. The lawyer also alleged that his client may be moved from Arthur Road Jail in Mumbai to Gujarat for interrogation by agencies other than the Central Bureau of Investigation and the Enforcement Directorate. The CPS, however, labelled them as ‘false premise’.

Burger Singh raises ₹82 cr Series B led by Artal Asia

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi



Kabir Jeet Singh, Founder, Burger Singh

Homegrown restaurant chain Burger Singh has raised its Series B funding round of ₹82 crore at a valuation of ₹520 crore.

The round was led by Artal Asia Pte Ltd, followed by Negen Undiscovered Value Fund and Aurum Rising India Fund, among others.

The company said it will use the fresh capital to strengthen systems, processes and infrastructure required to build a scalable franchise-first restaurant growth platform.

MORE FRANCHISES

With 200+ stores already in operation, Burger Singh will focus on deepening the company’s franchise engine across store design, training systems, operating manuals, supply chain integration, technology and on-ground market support, with the goal of making restaurant entrepreneurship in India more structured, scalable

and repeatable.

Kabir Jeet Singh, Founder and CEO, Burger Singh, said, “India has no shortage of entrepreneurs. What it lacks is enough high-quality operating platforms that allow those entrepreneurs to succeed in the restaurant business at scale. That is the gap we are solving. Burger Singh is building a franchise-first machine with the systems required to make store ownership more structured and more repeatable. We are not just opening outlets; we are building the platform entrepreneurs can plug in to create successful restaurant businesses.”

Belrise Industries acquires UK-based Chester Hall for £13.2 million

Press Trust of India
Mumbai

Belrise Industries on Wednesday said it has acquired UK-based precision engineering group Chester Hall at an enterprise value of £13.2 million, marking the company’s strategic entry into

high-value aerospace and space manufacturing.

Belrise UK Holdings, the step-down subsidiary of Belrise Industries, signed a definitive share purchase agreement to acquire 100 per cent of the issued share capital of Chester Hall Precision Engineering Holdings, according to a company state-

ment. The acquisition delivers immediate and compounding strategic value to Belrise across three dimensions, including instant access to advanced aerospace precision manufacturing capabilities and certifications, besides a platform to serve global aerospace OEMs and tier-1

suppliers at scale, the company said.

At the same time, it will also help integrate Belrise’s largescale manufacturing in India and France.

POWERFUL PLATFORM

“Chester Hall brings deep precision engineering capabilities and a sterling reputa-

tion within the aerospace supply chain, being recognised as a top supplier across all its major customers,” said Sumedh Badve, Head of Strategy, Belrise Industries.

“By combining their advanced engineering expertise with Belrise’s manufacturing scale, we are creating a powerful platform to parti-

cipate in the rapidly expanding global as well as Indian aerospace manufacturing ecosystem,” he said. This transaction is an important step in our strategy to build a truly diversified global engineering group, and to strengthen India’s role in the international aerospace supply chain, he added.

TELANGANA POWER GENERATION CORPORATION LIMITED
VIDYUT SOUDHA - HYDERABAD - 02.
T.No.e-66/CEG/SEG-1/ES/AB/KTPP/CHP/TGGENCO/2025-26
KTPP – Procurement of 02 Nos KOMATSU/CAT/KOBELCO/TATA HITACHI/HUNDAI make Hydraulic Excavator (Quarry Model), 133-145HP @ 2000 RPM fitted with HD bucket with AC cabin front grill for newly constructed additional CHP & Old CHP RC hopper at Kakatiya Thermal Power Project, Chelpur (V), Jayashankar Bhopalapally Dist. Value of the works: **₹1,10,00,000/-** Scheduled Open & Closing Date: **12.03.2026 at 18:00 Hrs. & 06.04.2026 at 11:00 Hrs.**
T.No.e-32/CE/Civil/Thermal/TGGENCO/2025-26
YTPS – Supply and fixing of Cubical partitions in the offices of all floors of Service buildings-I Stage-I at Yadadri Thermal Power Station, Veerlapalem (V), Dameracherla (Mdl), Nalagonda Dist. Value of the works:**₹63,27,500/-** Scheduled Open & Closing Date: **17.03.2026 at 17:00 Hrs. & 01.04.2026 at 17:00 Hrs.**
T.No.e-59/CE/O&M/KTPS-V&VI/CHP/TGGENCO/2025-26
KTPS- V&VI – Excavation & Transportation of Stagnated coal from Uncrushed Coal Yard (back side), old stacker (Road side) and yard surroundings to the grind for maintaining the bunker levels of units 9,10&11 at Kothagudem Thermal Power Station Stages-V&VI, Paloncha, Bhadradi Kothagudem Dist. With a lead of 1KM, Value of the works: **₹29,80,000/-** Scheduled Open & Closing Date: **13.03.2026 at 12:10 Hrs 09.04.2026 at 15:30 Hrs.**
T.No.e-394/CE/O&M/KTPS-VII/P42/EM/TGGENCO/2025-26
KTPS-VII – Procurement of EPR insulated fire Survival Power cables Quotation at Kothagudem Thermal Power Station Stage-VII, Paloncha, Bhadradi Kothagudem Dist. Scheduled Open & Closing Date: **13.03.2026 at 12:10 Hrs 09.04.2026 at 15:30 Hrs.**
T.No.e-65/CEG/SEG-1/EME-VII/TGGENCO/2026-27
KTPS- V – Remnant Life Assessment (RLA) and Condition assessment (CA) of boiler and its Auxiliaries as per Indian Boiler Regulations 1950, of Unit-X at Kothagudem Thermal Power Station Stage-V, Paloncha, Bhadradi Kothagudem Dist. Value of the works: **₹9,00,000/-** Scheduled Open & Closing Date: **10.03.2026 at 17:00 Hrs 06.04.2026 at 11:00 Hrs.**
DIPR R.O.No.1268-PP/CL-AGENCY/ADVT/1/2025-26 Dt: 18-03-2026

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TENDER NOTICE NO. ACE (P&C)-TN -25: 2025-2026
[A] PROCUREMENT: E-3092:- Purchase of 66/ 132/ 220/ 400 kV Raised Chimney Stub Tower material against Tender No. ACE (P&C)/ I/ E-3092/ Tower Material/ ARC/ 2025-26.
[B] CIVIL: ACE (P&C)/ Contracts/ Civil- 598, 599, 600, 601:- (1) Construction of Administrative Office Building for Dhansura AM Division including electrification, e-Urja connectivity work, Furniture, Parking, RCC Road, etc. at 220 kV Dhansura SS under Himatnagar Circle, (2) Construction of Compound wall, water sump, bore work, renovation of control room building including provision of ladies toilet, water proofing treatment and misc. civil work at 132 kV Nandesari S/s under Koyali Division under Jambuva Circle, (3) Construction of 1 No. of Type-III (G+3) residential quarters block with lift, including electrification works, septic tank, soak pit, RCC internal roads, parking shed, multipurpose area, and landscaping / garden development at 132 kV Mahemdabad S/s under Nadiad AM Division under Nadiad Circle, (4) Construction of Administrative Building (G+2) along with necessary amenities including Electrification, Plumbing, Fire safety system & other ancillary work for Asset Management Division & allied offices under Navsari Circle. (Phase -1).
[C] LINE: ACE (P&C)/ Contracts/ E-408, 422, 425/ TL/ UG/ 66kV, 132kV/ S&L,E:- (1) Supply, Laying, Erection, Testing and Commissioning 132kV 1Cx800sq mm 2* (3+0) XLPE U/G cable from 132kV Itola TSS to Termination tower DD+0 (route length 0.5 Rkms) & from 220 kV Jambuva S/s to Termination tower DD+0 (route length 1.250 RKms), (2) Supply, Laying, Erection, Testing and Commissioning of 66kV,1CX630 sqmm XLPE Cable with Poly. Al. / Aluminium construction on EPC basis Various lines under Bharuch Circle, (3) Supply, Laying, Erection, Testing and Commissioning of 132 kV D/C UG Cable line by laying of 132 kV, 800Sqmm (2x3) U/G Cable Line (route length – 1.0 km) from 220 kV Rupakheda (GETCO) S/s end to the switchyard of Proposed Dahod TSS (132 kV U/G Cable at 220 kV Rupakheda S/s end).
[D] SUBSTATION & LINE: ACE (P&C)/ Contract/ E-434/ 66 kV SS & OH TL/ Turnkey:- Supply, Erection, Testing, and commissioning of 66 kV equipment's & materials on Turnkey basis including civil works for 66 kV Substations and associated transmission lines (OH only) (Package-2 i.e., Amrel / Gondal / Jamnagar & Junagadh).
[E]ARC:ACE(P&C)/Contract/ARCEHVTR/E-435:-Annual Rate Contract (ARC) for Dismantling, Loading, Unloading, Transportation, Erection, Testing & commissioning of EHV class (132/220/400 kV) Power Transformer & 220 / 400 kV Reactors at various sub stations of GETCO.
Above tenders are available on website **www.getcogujarat.com** (for view and download only) & **tender.nprocure.com** (For view, download and online tender submissions).
Note: Bidders are requested to be in touch with our website till opening of these tenders.
Date: 19/03/2026
I/c. Additional Chief Engineer (Procurement & Contracts)

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QUICKLY.

Palm oil falls on weak rival oils, crude oil prices



Kuala Lumpur: Malaysian palm oil futures closed over 1 per cent lower on Wednesday for a second straight session as weaker rival edible oils and crude oil prices, as well as concerns over April export demand, weighed on sentiment. The benchmark palm oil contract for June delivery on the Bursa Malaysia Derivatives Exchange slid 49 ringgit to 4,532 ringgit (\$1,158.19) a tonne at the close. REUTERS

Aluminium prices hit one-week low

London: Aluminium prices fell on Wednesday as Emirates Global Aluminium secured alternative export routes to the Strait of Hormuz, easing some of the immediate worries about the Middle East supply. The benchmark three-month aluminium on the LME dropped 0.6 per cent to \$3,379.5 a tonne in official open-outcry trading after hitting \$3,336, the lowest level since March 10. REUTERS

Arabica falls on hopes of bumper Brazil crop



London: Arabica coffee futures on ICE were lower on Wednesday, weighed by the prospect of a bumper crop in Brazil this year, while cocoa prices also fell. Arabica coffee fell 1.9 per cent to \$2.8915 per lb by 1318GMT. Robusta coffee rose 1.5 per cent to \$3,580 a tonne. REUTERS

Gold jewellery sales may jump 40% during *Gudi Padwa*, *Ugadi*

POSITIVE SPIN. Industry expects recent price drop to boost light-weight jewellery demand

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

Jewellers in India are expecting a 40 per cent rise in gold jewellery demand during the Marathi new year *Gudi Padwa*, and Telugu and Kannada new year *Ugadi*, which fall on Thursday. The industry anticipates the recent fall in gold prices to boost demand for light-weight jewellery, in particular.

Gold prices fell by ₹789 to ₹1,54,879 per 10 g on Wednesday against ₹1,55,668 on Tuesday. Gold has crashed by ₹12,592 from ₹1,67,471 since March 2.

Rajesh Rokde, Chairman, Gem and Jewellery Council, said despite elevated gold prices, jewellers were optimistic that *Gudi Padwa* and *Ugadi* will witness strong consumer sentiment due to deep cultural significance.

While volatility in the international markets may keep prices firm in the near



MUTED SHINE. Gold prices fell by ₹789 to ₹1,54,879 per 10 g on Wednesday against ₹1,55,668 on Tuesday PTI

term, the industry expects demand to remain resilient, with consumers increasingly opting for lighter jewellery pieces and innovative designs. The festive spirit, coupled with the ongoing wedding season, will ensure that sales momentum stays healthy at 7-8 tonnes on Thursday compared to 5 tonnes last year, he said.

MINDFUL BUYING
Sachin Jain, Regional CEO, India, World Gold Council, said the current festive season, beginning with *Gudi*

Padwa, *Ugadi*, *Cheti Chand* and *Chaitra Navratri*, comes at a time when gold demand in India is showing both continuity and change.

The demand has widened, with interest not just in jewellery but also in bars, coins, ETFs and digital gold, as more consumers look at gold through both a consumption and increasingly an investment lens, he said.

Saurabh Gadgil, Chairman and Managing Director, PNG Jewellers, said *Gudi Padwa* had set a strong start to the season, backed by encour-

aging pre-bookings and positive consumer sentiment.

“With the upcoming wedding season and *Akshay Tritiya*, demand visibility remains robust across categories. Lightweight jewellery continues to drive volumes, while wedding jewellery is seeing steady traction,” he said.

Overall, PNG Jewellers expects to deliver a healthy value growth of 20-25 per cent over last year, he said.

Colin Shah, MD, Kama Jewelry, said auspicious occasions like *Gudi Padwa* attract a large number of buyers, driven by sentimental value. This year, domestic jewellery sales during *Gudi Padwa* are likely to remain neutral, irrespective of the downtrend in gold prices after a long time. “While some buyers from the investors’ fraternity may leverage this opportunity, the consumer class will be mindful, given the current geopolitical scenario,” he said.

Centre curbs import of jewellery studded with low-cost diamonds

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The Centre has restricted the import of gold and silver jewellery studded with cheap diamonds amid the discount of \$30 an ounce offered in Dubai. In a notification issued on Wednesday, the government imposed a ban on the import of gold and silver jewellery studded with low-value diamonds.

While both gold and silver prices have taken a beating of late, the long-term prospects of both precious metals appear to be firm given the raging war between the US and Iran. With heavy bombings by Iran, financial activities, including bullion trade, and tourism in Dubai have come to a standstill.

Prithviraj Kothari, President, India Bullion and Jewellers Association, said the move to place imports of gold and silver jewellery studded with diamonds under the restricted list is aimed at curbing indiscriminate inflows, improving traceability and protecting domestic manufacturers.



The move is aimed at curbing indiscriminate inflows, improving traceability and protecting domestic manufacturers

PRITHVIRAJ KOTHARI
President, India Bullion and Jewellers Association



It likely comes at a time when authorities are focusing on reducing trade imbalances and preventing misuse of import channels for duty arbitrage, he said.

In the near term, this could tighten supply, increase compliance costs and support local jewellery production, he added.

For the industry, it encourages value addition within India but may disrupt supply chains for exporters dependent on imported finished products, said Kothari.

UNTIL JUNE 30
This has forced many bullion dealers to offer a discount of \$30 an ounce. Once flight services resume, gold and sil-

ver jewellery may flow into India, putting temporary pressure on domestic prices.

Amid this, the government has now amended the regulation concerning gold and silver, and has issued a formal notification regarding the same.

As per the notification issued by the Directorate-General of Foreign Trade, the import policy for these specific items has been reclassified from ‘free’ to ‘restricted.’ This rule has come into effect immediately and will remain operative until June 30. The DGFT stated that, under this decision, controls will be exercised over the import of the relevant commodities.

With mercury rising & uneven rain, El Nino to emerge: APEC Climate Center

Srikrishnan PC
Chennai

The APEC Climate Center (APCC) has issued an El Nino Watch in its monthly report, indicating a probable warming phase in the coming months. Temperatures are expected to remain above normal across most parts of the globe, with limited exceptions.

Rainfall patterns may shift unevenly, bringing wetter conditions to parts of the Pacific, while drier conditions are likely over the Maritime Continent, India, and nearby regions through mid-2026,

affecting agriculture, water resources and overall climate stability, said the APCC report.

Drought-bearing El Nino is a largescale warming of sea surface temperatures in the central and eastern equatorial Pacific, accompanied by shifts in tropical atmospheric circulation, including changes in wind patterns, air pressure and rainfall distribution.

An El Nino event weakens India’s South West monsoon, often triggering drought-like conditions.

In 2023, the event began in June and persisted for 11 months. It affected food-



DRIED OUT. An El Nino event weakens India’s South West monsoon, often triggering drought-like conditions

grain output, leading to reduced production levels. The fallout also pushed up food inflation.

It said there will be a tend-

ency towards below-normal rainfall in the southern Indian Ocean, southern Australia and the Bay of Bengal.

The report predicted that

there will be a higher probability of below-normal rainfall across the western to central North Pacific, the off-equatorial eastern North Pacific and the tropical western Atlantic. It forecast an increased probability for below-normal rainfall for India, eastern Central Africa, Southern Australia, the tropical South Pacific and the western tropical Atlantic.

HIGH TEMPERATURES

It said there was a stronger possibility of below-normal rainfall in the southern subtropical Indian Ocean, the Caribbean, Central America and the northern part of

South America.

There was increased probability of above-normal temperatures across the equatorial Indian Ocean, the Arabian Sea, north-eastern Atlantic, the Mediterranean, central Africa, East Asia and North Pacific, tropical North Pacific, Caribbean, subtropical North Atlantic, south-eastern South Pacific and northwestern parts of South America.

Above-normal temperatures are expected across South Asia, West Asia, Central Asia, Europe, the Arctic Sea, Russia, Greenland, North Africa, the United States, Central America and

southern South America. A general tendency toward above-normal temperatures is also expected in southern Australia and Canada.

A higher probability of near-normal temperatures has been predicted for the central subtropical South Pacific, while a tendency toward below-normal temperatures is expected over the southeastern subtropical Indian Ocean and the tropical North Atlantic.

Enhanced probability for below-normal temperatures is predicted for the southern part of the North Atlantic and northern Australia, said the APCC report.

Tea imports doubled to 50.14 m kg in 2024-25

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

Tea imports doubled in 2024-25 compared with the 2023-24 fiscal, while 33.5 million kg were imported during April-January this fiscal, according to a reply in the Lok Sabha on Tuesday.

In a written reply, Jitin Prasada, Union Minister of State for Commerce and Industry, said India imported 50.14 million kg of tea during 2024-25 against 25.21 million kg in 2023-24. In fact, India imported a significant quantity of tea during the first 10 months of 2025-26. Tea imports stood at 33.55 million kg during April-January of 2025-26.

Stating that the Tea Board had taken several measures in respect of teas imported into the country, he said the government issued a notific-

ation dated November 11, 2021, with a directive stating that imported tea must not be blended with GI teas, and if blending is done, the end product must not be claimed as GI tea.

Directives were issued to packers, requiring them to clearly indicate on the packaging that the blended tea contains imported ingredients. Importers and exporters have been directed to mandatorily obtain clearance certificates from the board’s Tea Council portal before importing or exporting tea, and the origin must be clearly mentioned on the tea packages.

WOMEN FPOS

He said the importers should notify to the Tea Board the place of storage of the imported teas within 24 hours of import. The importers shall ensure that origin of the im-



ported teas is mentioned in all sale invoices.

In a written reply to a question on women in farmer producers organisations (FPOs), Bhagirath Choudhary, Union Minister of State for Agriculture and Farmers’ Welfare, said 1,175 FPOs had been registered as 100 per cent women members under the 10,000 FPOs

scheme till March 1 2026. He said 23.55 lakh women farmers were registered across the country under the 10,000 FPOs scheme till March 1.

To a question on fish landing centres in the country, Rajiv Ranjan Singh, Union Minister for Fisheries, Animal Husbandry and Dairy, said the government had so far taken up development of 380 notified fish landing centres and fishing harbours, out of the total 1,547 notified fish landing centres.

Of the 380 fish landing centres taken up for development, works on 301 have already been completed.

The formulation of projects are done by the respective State/Union Territories by prioritising the projects as per technical and financial viability, social impact and availability of budget in the concerned State/Union Territory.

Panel endorses subsidy on e-tractors

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

The Standing Committee on Agriculture, Animal Husbandry and Food Processing has recommended subsidy on electric tractors and educational support for children of small and marginal farmers, among others related to the farm sector.

While suggesting that the budget allocation for the agriculture department be increased to deal with challenges like climate change and market volatility, the panel also raised concerns over profits from the purchase of milk not reaching the farmers as big cooperatives corner it.

The panel presented a separate report on the demands for grants (2026-27) of the Department of Agriculture and Farmers’ Welfare, Ministry of Cooperation and other related departments in the Lok Sabha on Monday.

During the discussion of



the Committee, the issue of subsidies for electric tractors was raised to make them economically viable vis-a-vis diesel tractors, thereby boosting farmer acceptance and making them affordable for small and marginal farmers. RJD MP Sudhakar Singh, a member of the panel, is said to have written to the Chairman of the Committee on the issue.

SUSTAINABLE FARMING

“The Committee feels that electric tractors are vital for sustainable farming as they cut diesel emissions significantly, thereby promoting a greener planet with lesser

The panel also recommended scaling up EV charging infrastructure in rural areas to make electric tractors popular

carbon emissions. They also promote energy independence via solar charging and align them with India’s net zero goals. The Committee recommends that proportionate subsidies may be given on electric tractors to that of diesel tractors to make them economically feasible and boost their acceptance among the farmers, especially small and marginal farmers. The Committee also recommends that infrastructure relating to EV charging facilities may also be scaled up in rural areas to make electric tractors popular among the farmers,” the report said.

Copper: Retain short position at ₹1,230

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau

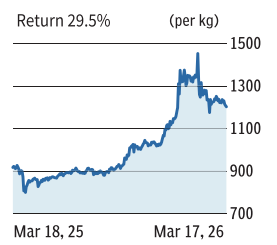
Copper futures have been gradually dropping since the beginning of this month and are now trading at ₹1,168 (per kg). The outlook remains bearish.

COMMODITY CALL.

On Wednesday, the March contract slipped below the low of ₹1,169.2 made on February 17. This reinforces the bearish position, especially considering that the nearest support from the current level is at ₹1,150.

Therefore, we expect copper to soon drop to ₹1,150. A breach of this could open the door for a decline to ₹1,110, where it could meet a strong rising trendline support.

On the other hand, if copper recovers from the current level of ₹1,168, it will



face resistance between ₹1,180 and ₹1,185. A breakout of the latter could turn the immediate outlook positive. Until then, the bearish outlook will remain.

TRADE STRATEGY

We suggested initiating a short position at ₹1,230 a couple of weeks ago. Hold on to the trade. But revise the stop-loss from ₹1,260 to ₹1,210 to protect some profits. Book profits at ₹1,150.

Do not initiate fresh shorts now since the risk-reward ratio is unfavourable.

‘Introduce ethanol-based cookstoves’

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

The Grain Ethanol Manufacturers Association (GEMA) has asked the government to introduce ethanol-based cookstoves as a clean cooking solution for Indian households as well as commercial users.

In a letter to the Prime Minister and other Ministers, CK Jain, President of GEMA, said the introduction of ethanol cookstoves could be examined as a complementary option alongside LPG for both domestic households and commercial establishments, such as restaurants, street vendors and institutional kitchens. This could help diversify India’s clean cooking energy mix, enhance resilience in the cooking fuel sector and create new avenues for the utilisation of domestically produced biofuels.

GEMA requested the government to consider initiat-



ing an appropriate study or pilot programme through the departments concerned, oil marketing companies and technical institutions to examine the technical feasibility, safety standards and economic viability of ethanol-based cooking solutions in India.

ENERGY SECURITY

Jain said the situation in West Asia remained uncertain due to ongoing geopolitical tensions. This may have implications for global energy supply chains and pricing. Such developments highlight the importance of strengthening India’s long-term energy security by diversifying domestic energy

options, wherever feasible.

Mentioning that India had successfully built a robust domestic ethanol ecosystem under the Ethanol Blended Petrol Programme and the National Policy on Biofuels, he said the expansion of ethanol production had not only supported the transport fuel sector but had also strengthened the agricultural economy and enhanced the country’s biofuel capabilities. “In this context, ethanol-based cookstoves may present an opportunity to explore an additional application of domestically produced biofuels. Such cookstoves are being adopted in several countries as a clean and efficient cooking solution,” he said.

If found suitable, ethanol cookstoves could evolve as an additional clean energy option for consumers, he said, adding that GEMA would assist the Ministry in any consultations or technical discussions required in this regard.

QUICKLY.

Uranium projects near approval: Jitendra Singh

New Delhi: The Uranium Corporation of India Ltd (UCIL) is set to establish a uranium mining and processing plant with a capacity of 2,500 tonnes per day (TPD) at Rohil in Rajasthan's Sikar district and Jajwal, Chhattisgarh, said Union Minister Jitendra Singh on Wednesday. In a written reply to the Lok Sabha, the Minister said the mining projects were under various stages of obtaining statutory clearances.

No disbursals made in solar PLI as of Feb: Govt

New Delhi: Solar equipment manufacturers have not received any funds under the ₹24,000 crore production linked incentive (PLI) scheme till February-end, Parliament was informed on Wednesday. The Ministry of New and Renewable Energy, Government of India, is implementing the PLI Scheme for high efficiency solar PV modules with an outlay of ₹24,000 crore.

Physicswallah gets ₹263 cr income tax demand notice

New Delhi: Edtech firm Physicswallah has received an income tax demand notice of ₹263.34 crore for the assessment year 2023-24. The demand was raised after the Income Tax Department treated investments received by the company from investors during the period, including funds from SEBI-registered Category II Alternative Investment Funds, as taxable income, Physicswallah said in a regulatory filing. The company plans to challenge the assessment order. "The company believes that it has strong legal and factual grounds to file an appeal," Physicswallah said.

Govt brings solar ingots, wafers under ALMM from June 2028

NUTS & BOLTS. Move to enhance supply chain resilience, reduce import dependence and ensure better quality

Our Bureau New Delhi

The Ministry of New & Renewable Energy (MNRE) said on Wednesday that it has expanded the Approved List of Models and Manufacturers (ALMM) Order to include ingots and wafers with effect from June 1, 2028.

Suitable grandfathering provisions have been built in to protect projects already in the pipeline, said the Ministry.

The current order of the MNRE extends mandatory sourcing requirements from ALMM lists, already in place for modules and cells, to include ingots and wafers, which are heavily import-dependent, it added.

MNRE Minister Pralhad Joshi said it is a decisive step towards strengthening India's solar manufacturing ecosystem.

The Minister said the move will boost domestic production, enhance supply chain resilience, reduce import dependence and ensure higher quality standards across the solar value chain.

The ALMM Order 2019 is a quality-and-reliability framework that ensures solar equipment meet domestic manufacturing standards.

IMPORT HEAVY

Vinay Rustagi, Chief Business Officer of Premier Energies, said, "Currently, 100 per cent of our demand for solar wafers is met from imports, making the sector highly prone to supply shocks, exchange rate volatility and trade disruption. We expect total investment of around ₹50,000 crore over the next three years. Premier Energies has already announced a plan to set up 10 GW ingot-wafer capacity, costing ₹5,900 crore."



BUILDING CAPACITY. Manufacturers seeking enlistment in ALMM List-III for wafers must also have equivalent ingot manufacturing capacity REUTERS

Sharing similar views, Prashant Mathur, CEO of Saatvik Green Energy, noted that the policy vindicates the foresight of companies that invested early in integrated, end-to-end domestic manufacturing.

Manufacturers seeking enlistment in ALMM List-III for wafers must also have equivalent ingot manufac-

turing capacity, promoting upstream integration for ingots.

POLICY PUSH

Gautam Mohanka, Director of Gautam Solar, said the long-term outlook remains highly promising, with the policy accelerating development of a self-reliant upstream manufacturing base.

As govt expands ALMM list, industry seeks capex support

Rohan Das Chennai

Even as the government's move to include ingots and wafers as part of the Approved List of Models and Manufacturers (AIMM) order is expected to accelerate localisation of the components, the industry has flagged the need for capital support.

PRODUCTION CAPACITY

Speaking to *businessline*, industry executives said the current domestic production capacity for these components is negligible.

They add that manufacturing ingots and wafers at scale is capital intensive and the government should encourage incentives and subsidies for further investments in this space.

Subrahmanyam Pulipaka, Chief Executive Officer, National Solar Energy Federation of India (NSEFI), said the capital expenditure per GW of ingot and wafer manufacturing is around ₹1,000 crore and for sustainable manufacturing to thrive, at least 40 per cent and up to 50 per cent of viability gap funding (VGF) is required from the government.



The Federation has requested the MNRE for a VGF of ₹20,000-25,000 crore for ingot and wafer manufacturing to support the installa-

tion of about 50 GW of capacity.

UPFRONT COSTS

The industry believes there will be some increase in upfront costs as prices of ingots and wafers produced domestically are expected to go up.

Arul Shanmugasundram, CEO and Managing Director SWELECT Energy Systems Ltd, said, "Energy costs are much lower in China. Our production level right now is subscale. Even in terms of quality, it will take time for us to build at their level."

Hardip Singh, COO,

GREW Solar, added that though there may be some impact on upfront costs in the initial phase, with scale, backward integration and improved efficiencies, costs are expected to become competitive over time.

GREW Solar plans to set up an 8 GW ingot and wafer manufacturing facility by 2027.

Laxit Awla, Executive Director and CEO, SAEL Industries Ltd, echoed this, suggesting that the policy will catalyse backward integration, reducing exposure to volatile global pricing and supply disruptions.

RFT Aviation-Charlie Foxtrot consortium to establish flight training school at Thoothukudi

T E Raja Simhan Chennai

Pune-based RFT Aviation Academy LLP and the Delhi-based Charlie Foxtrot Aviation Services will establish a Flight Training Organisation (FTO) in Kovilpatti in Thoothukudi.

They are the successful bidder for the project in a tender issued by the Tamil Nadu Industrial Development Corporation (Tidco).

Confirming the development, Capt Trupti Ashish Karnavat, Founder of RFT Aviation, said in a social media post that the project was formally initiated on March 7 with a site visit and ceremonial pooja.

Kovilpatti, known for its match box industry and *kadalai mittai* (groundnut chikki), hosts an unused airstrip originally built by Lakshmi Mills for private air-



NEW BEGINNING. Capt Trupti Ashish Karnavat (right), Founder, RFT Aviation, said in a social media post that the project was initiated on March 7 with a site visit and ceremonial pooja

craft operations.

Spread across 63 hectares leased from the State government in Nalatinputhur and Thonugal villages, the facility lies about 6 km from the town.

According to an earlier request for proposal issued by Tidco, the asphalt runway measures 1.2 km in length and 15 metres in width, though it is currently unus-

able. The site can accommodate up to 10 aircraft.

The hourly flying fee payable to Tidco has been fixed with a minimum reserve price of ₹500 per flying hour.

Once operational, this will be Tamil Nadu's second FTO, following the EKVI Aircraft Training Organisation facility in Salem, which was cleared by the Director-

ate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) in July 2023.

ANOTHER FTO PROJECT

Tidco is also in the process of awarding another FTO project at Kanadukathan in the Karaikudi district.

Separately, the Airports Authority of India (AAI) plans to set up an FTO at Thoothukudi airport, around 65 km from Kovilpatti. For this project, the concession will be awarded based on a fee rate, with a minimum of ₹675 per flying hour per aircraft.

Industry experts say both locations offer distinct advantages. Abhinav Singh noted that while Thoothukudi has an established runway and infrastructure, Kovilpatti offers unrestricted flying conditions due to the absence of scheduled commercial traffic — an advantage for pilot training operations.

Maharashtra to set up tribunal to address IT employees' grievances

Vallari Sanzgiri Mumbai

The Maharashtra State government will set up a separate tribunal for grievances flagged by employees in the IT sector, Labour Minister Akash Fundkar told the Assembly on Wednesday.

The State will be the first to set up such a cell, in line with the Industrial Relations Code, 2020, to be finalised by the Centre.

"Pune is recognised as an IT hub globally. The new codes provide for a special tribunal for the IT sector. Maharashtra, too, will form these tribunals. Once these codes are finalised, we will do the needful," said Fundkar. His statement came in response to queries by Chinchwad MLA Shankar Jagtap, who sought a timeline for the establishment of such tribunals amid



allegations of forced lay-offs, delayed full and final settlements, PF-related issues and others.

STORY SO FAR

On February 23, the government had called a meeting to address employees' concerns, including complaints from the IT sector.

Jagtap sought the number of complaints received and pushed for a helpline number for the complainants. These queries, however, were not addressed during

Vaishnaw points to record allocation for rlys as LS clears ₹2.78 lakh cr grants

Rohit Vaid New Delhi



Ashwini Vaishnaw, Union Minister of Railways

The Lok Sabha on Tuesday passed the Demands for Grants for the Railways for 2026-27, concluding a two-day debate that saw participation from over 210 MPs.

MPs demanded the introduction of Vande Bharat train services in their constituencies, the reinstatement of trains suspended during Covid, and the restoration of concessions for elderly passengers and other categories.

Vaishnaw presented a comprehensive 10-point response covering railway infrastructure, passenger services, safety systems and employment generation.

BOOSTS FUNDING

The Minister said the merger of the railway budget with the general Budget had strengthened the sector's financial position.

Earlier, annual allocations for railway projects were ₹24,000-₹25,000 crore and occasionally touched ₹30,000 crore. Funding had increased to around ₹2.78 lakh crore in 2026-27. The arrangement also enabled decisions such as sanctioning projects, introducing trains, approving stoppages, and adopting technology to be taken throughout the year.

FINANCIAL HEALTH

The Minister said the Railways' financial health had improved over the past decade.

On the expenditure front, he revealed that staff costs remained the largest around ₹1.19 lakh crore, followed by energy costs (₹32,000 crore), financing costs (₹23,000 crore) and pension liabilities (₹64,000 crore).

He said the shift from diesel to electricity had

CAPACITY ADDITION

Further, capacity expansion in freight and passenger operations continued. As per the Minister, 128 cargo terminals had been commissioned; 162 Vande Bharat services and 60 Amrit Bharat train services had also been introduced.

Rolling stock capacity had also increased. The number of wagons, which stood at 3,46,000, had now risen to a record 3,86,000. Passenger capacity had also expanded, with 98,000 coaches currently part of the network.

Currently, 25,571 trains are running daily across the country. The government, he said, provides about ₹60,000 crore (45 per cent concession on ticket costs) annually in passenger subsidies.

'Industry' definition to ruling to cover pending cases: SC

Press trust of India New Delhi

A nine-judge Constitution bench of the Supreme Court on Wednesday said its verdict on the correctness of a 1978 judgment, which gives an expansive interpretation of the term "industry" to govern labour relations, will apply to existing cases under the now-repealed Industrial Disputes Act, 1947.

On February 21, 1978, a seven-judge bench expanded the definition of the term "industry" while deciding the plea of the Bangalore Water Supply and Sewerage Board and brought millions of employees in hospitals, educational institutions, clubs and government welfare departments under the protection of the Industrial Disputes Act, 1947.

The nine-judge bench, including Chief Justice Surya Kant, is hearing submissions.

NMPA sets up holding unit for cargo hit by Gulf crisis

Our Bureau Mangaluru

The New Mangalore Port Authority (NMPA) has announced steps to mitigate hardships faced by port users due to the ongoing conflict in West Asia.

In a notice dated March 17, NMPA announced measures like a facility for stranded containers in the terminal's container yards/port storage area till the cargo is shipped out. NMPA and the terminal operator are in touch with Customs authorities to facilitate storage of laden containers from other ports bound for West Asia.

NMPA shall waive ground rent and reefer plug-in charges for the stranded export containers, it said. The port authority will

accommodate stranded cargo and facilitate emergency discharge for vessels transiting to West Asia.

A covered shed and an open yard are earmarked for stranded and transit cargo — both containerised and perishable — with adequate facility for stuffing and destuffing. Dedicated storage zones have been earmarked for perishable cargo and reefer containers.

It said the container terminal operator had been asked to augment resources for additional storage demand, consider waiver on ground rent, dwell time of cargo and de-congest any vessels, especially those bound for West Asia, waiting for the container berth.

PRIORITY BERTHING

NMPA also assured priority berthing for LPG vessels.

CAT issues notice to Centre, Employees State Insurance on plea of bias in nursing officer postings

Our Bureau New Delhi

The Central Administrative Tribunal (CAT) on Wednesday issued notice to the Union Ministry of Labour and the Employees' State Insurance Corporation (ESIC) over discriminatory treatment of meritorious reserved category candidates at the time of allocating zones for posting as nursing officers in ESIC hospitals across the country.

A bench, presided over by RV Sinha, sought the response of ESIC over meritorious Schedule Caste (SC) and Other Backward Classes (OBC) candidates being denied posting to preferred zones, which were allocated to less meritorious candidates of their category, in violation of government policy



RULE BREACH. The ESIC decision is against the principles of justice, equity and law expounded by the Supreme Court and clarified by the DoPT on June 4, 2010

and judicial dicta.

A batch of one SC and six OBC candidates approached the Tribunal after the ESIC failed to act on their representation, pointing out that they were being made to suffer merely because they performed well in the recruitment test and were counted in the unreserved category.

Counsel for the applicants, Gyanant Singh, submit-

ted that the applicants had given their order of preferences for zones, which were to be allocated on merit.

He pointed out that the Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT) had laid down the policy of accommodating meritorious reserved category candidates on the basis of their merit position at the time of posting or allocation of service,

even after being counted in the general unreserved quota.

The applicants had submitted that there was no basis for the methodology adopted for allocating ESIC hospitals after seeking the order of preference from candidates in the merit list declared by the Union Public Service Commission.

ESIC DECISION

The ESIC decision is against the principles of justice, equity and law expounded by the Supreme Court and clarified by the DoPT on June 4, 2010, they said.

"The ESIC has not just acted arbitrarily against the mandate of law, but has also not disclosed the complete list, order of preference and the State/region allocated to them," the petition before CAT read.

AP CM disburses over ₹226 cr in third phase to Polavaram project affected

Press Trust of India Amaravati

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu on Wednesday announced the disbursement of ₹226 crore as part of the third phase of compensation for those displaced by the Polavaram irrigation project.

The government said the compensation was being given in view of the Ugadi festival.

"The Chief Minister handed over a cheque for ₹226 crore under the third phase of the rehabilitation package for the evacuees," an official press release said.

According to officials, around ₹1,943 crore has been paid over 21 months, including ₹800 crore during

Sankranti and ₹916 crore during Diwali as part of compensation to Polavaram evacuees. The project is being implemented in phases, with rehabilitation colonies under development, while additional funds are being mobilised to complete pending works.

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QUICKLY.

Thousands affected as X hit by major global outage

New Delhi: Microblogging platform X on Wednesday faced a major technical snag as thousands of users globally, including in India, reported that the service was down. According to Downdetector, reports of the platform being inaccessible began spiking shortly after 8pm IST, with users across various regions reporting issues with both the mobile application and the desktop website. Users in Delhi, Mumbai, Bengaluru and Hyderabad, reported difficulties in refreshing their timelines, viewing replies, and posting new updates. **PTI**

Zydus, Torrent partner to co-market Semaglutide

Ahmedabad: Zydus Lifesciences Limited and Torrent Pharmaceuticals Limited have entered into a licensing and supply agreement to co-market semaglutide injection in India, targeting diabetes and weight management. Zydus will manufacture and supply the drug, while Torrent Pharma will have semi-exclusive rights to co-market it under the brand Sembolic, leveraging its strong presence in chronic therapies. **OUR BUREAU**

Mankind acquires Roche's Rivrotiril brand for India



Mumbai: Mankind Pharma has acquired Rivotril from Roche for the Indian market, with exclusive rights for domestic manufacture, marketing and distribution of the product, the company said. The acquisition bolsters Mankind's neurological products portfolio. **OUR BUREAU**

Advance tax collection grew by 6.42% in FY26, show I-T data

RISING CONCERNS. Revised estimates for FY26 are likely to be met, but experts see impact of West Asia war

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

Even after a de-growth in mop up from non-corporate tax (NCT) assesses, advance tax collection, after all the four instalments, rose by over 6 per cent during the current fiscal year, data from the Income Tax Department showed on Wednesday.

Experts feel that though revised estimates for FY26 are likely to be met, the coming months will see the impact of the West Asia war.

Growth in collection from all four instalments of advance tax during FY25 was over 14.6 per cent.

Non-corporate tax includes taxes paid by individuals, HUFs, firms, Association of Persons (AoPs),



Direct tax collection					(April 1-March 17/₹ lakh crore, Change in %)				
Net direct tax collection					Advance tax collection (After all instalments)				
Head	24-25	25-26	Chg		Head	24-25	25-26	Chg	
Corporate tax	9.68	10.92	12.8		Corporate tax	7.57	8.3	9.54	
Non-corporate tax	11.03	11.32	2.63						
STT	0.53	0.56			Non-corporate tax	2.88	2.83(-)1.78		
Net collection	21.27	22.8	7.19						
Refunds	4.62	4.34 (-)5.86			Total	10.46	11.13	6.42	

Source: CBDT

Body of Individuals (BoIs), local authorities and artificial juridical person.

CBDT DATA

Data from CBDT showed that advance tax collection from corporates grew by around 9.5 per cent, while that from NCT declined by around 2 per cent.

This could be the result of the rate revision during the

current fiscal. “While the growth in advance tax for corporate taxes appears relatively healthy, we are watchful of the unfolding impact of the West Asia crisis, on availability and pricing of inputs as well as profitability in certain sectors,” Aditi Nayar, Chief Economist, ICRA Ltd, said. Meanwhile, overall net direct collection recorded a growth of over 7 per

cent with double digit growth in corporate tax, but below 3 per cent in NCT.

MODERATE PACE

According to Jayesh Sanghvi, Tax Partner, EY India, personal income tax collections are progressing at a more moderate pace, as the impact of recent rate revisions will take additional time to fully filter through. Overall, “the

Claude gains in enterprise AI, ChatGPT stays dominant overall

Sanjana B
Bengaluru

Anthropic is carving out a stronger foothold in enterprise workflows as Claude gains traction in deep reasoning use cases, even as OpenAI's ChatGPT retains its lead in mainstream adoption.

According to data from Menlo Ventures, in the coding market, Anthropic commanded an estimated 54 per cent market share in December 2025, compared to 21 per cent for OpenAI.

This is up from 42 per cent just six months ago, driven largely by the popularity of Claude Code.

This comes even as OpenAI's ChatGPT contin-

ues to dominate the AI chatbot market with an 80.04 per cent share, while Anthropic's Claude trails at 1.34 per cent as of February 2026, according to data from StatCounter.

CODING BENCHMARK

According to a blog post by Anthropic, Claude 4.6 tops the agentic coding benchmark Terminal-Bench 2.0 and outperforms other frontier models on Humanity's Last Exam, a complex multidisciplinary reasoning test.

On GDPval-AA — an evaluation of performance across economically valuable knowledge-work tasks, such as finance and legal — Opus 4.6 surpasses OpenAI's GPT-5.2 and its predecessor, Claude Opus 4.5. However,

enterprises are moving away from evaluating AI models solely based on raw intelligence benchmarks or public leaderboards, Anushree Verma, Senior Director Analyst at Gartner, noted.

Because the capabilities of top-tier models, like those from OpenAI, Google and Anthropic, are reaching parity and their distinct technical advantages erode quickly, organisations are shifting their evaluation criteria toward ecosystem integration, cost efficiency and operational control.

STRONGEST FOOTING

“Claude has found its strongest footing in enterprise teams where the task is long, technically demanding or ambiguous. We have seen



that Claude holds up better under real enterprise conditions, like multi-step tasks with unstated assumptions, changing constraints and the need to maintain coherent context across long interactions,” said Varun Viswanath, Agent Engineer at Prodigal, an AI start-up using Claud Sonnet 4.5 for its production use cases.

Within enterprise enviro-

nnments, Claude has gained traction in reasoning-heavy and coding-focused workloads. Engineering teams frequently use Claude models for tasks such as code generation, debugging, architecture explanation and technical documentation.

COMPLEX TASKS

Beyond coding, Claude is used for complex analytical tasks like reviewing internal documents, synthesising technical reports or performing structured reasoning across multiple inputs.

GPT models remain widely used for general-purpose productivity tasks, customer support automation and applications where conversational fluency and broad reasoning are critical.

More ministries may gain content takedown powers

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

The government is considering authorising some more Ministries, including Defence, External Affairs and Home Affairs, to issue content takedown orders to social media platforms, sources said on Wednesday.

Inter-ministerial discussions are currently underway, government sources said, but they did not provide a timeline for when this may be implemented.

CURBING MENACE

At present, the Ministry of Electronics and IT (MeitY) is the nodal Ministry for take-downs and content blocking orders. Discussions are on with the Ministries of Defence, External Affairs and Home Affairs, government sources said.

Section 69A of the IT Act, 2000, empowers the Centre to block public access to on-



line content, websites, apps or social media posts in the interest of national security, sovereignty and public order.

In February, the Centre tightened rules for social media platforms such as YouTube and X, mandating the takedown of unlawful content within three hours and requiring clear labelling of all AI-generated content. The new rules came in response to the growing misuse of AI to create and circulate deceptive and obscene content on social media platforms.

+ Pilot body demands rollback of flight duty relaxations to Air India, flags fatigue risks

Press Trust of India
Mumbai

Pilots' group ALPA India on Wednesday urged the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) to roll back the latest relaxations granted to Air India for two-pilot long-haul flights amid the West Asia conflict, saying pilots will be exposed to an “unacceptable level of fatigue risk”.

KEY CONCERNS

In a letter to the DGCA, the association raised concerns about the relaxation of flight duty time limitations (FDTL) norms for Boeing 787 operations in the wake of the West Asia conflict.

Last week, the DGCA provided temporary relaxations — extending the flight time by 1.30 hours to 11.30 hours and the flight duty period by 1.45 hours to 11.45



SOARING TROUBLES. The temporary relaxations in FDTL norms are applicable till April 30

hours — in flight duty norms for Air India's long-haul flights as the airline is taking longer routes due to the airspace curbs amid the West Asia conflict, sources had said. These temporary relaxations in FDTL norms are applicable till April 30.

PRIOR CONSULTATION

While acknowledging that the relaxations were necessitated by the current situation, ALPA India flagged that there was lack of prior consultation with respect to

the non-reclining pilot seats in Boeing 787 aircraft.

“The lack of prior consultation, particularly for Boeing 787 operations (non-reclining pilot seat), has understandably caused understandable concern among crews already stretched thin,” the association's President Captain Sam Thomas said in the letter.

LONGER ROUTES

The DGCA has provided temporary relaxations in flight duty norms for Air In-

dia's long-haul flights as the airline is taking longer routes due to the curbs caused by the West Asia conflict.

The pilot's group sought war-risk insurance coverage for the crew, staff and passengers as a kind of explicit reassurance that they are comprehensively covered by additional insurance overriding the standard “war risk exclusion” clauses in legacy policies. “Such confirmation would alleviate deep-seated anxieties and affirm the value placed on their trust. We urge the DGCA to kindly compel airlines to confirm this by means of a special circular for the benefit of the crew and for the solace of their families,” it added.

On Tuesday, the group asked members to ensure that airlines carry out “appropriate operational risk assessments” before planning flights in or near conflict-affected areas.

BPM hiring focus pivots to AI-literate workforce even as roles transform

Sanjana B
Bengaluru

AI is not shrinking the business process management (BPM) workforce as much as it is rewiring it — shifting the industry away from a linear, headcount-led growth model towards one defined by productivity, digital fluency and outcome ownership, industry experts highlighted.

“The old ‘linear growth’ model, where more clients meant more desks, is fading. AI is decoupling revenue from headcount. Over the next two years, hiring won't be about finding processors to follow a script, but finding AI-literate problem solvers who can manage the complex, nuanced tasks machines still struggle with,” Aditya Narayan Mishra, MD and CEO of CIEL HR, noted.

However, instead of reducing hiring demand, AI is



EMPLOYMENT SHIFT. AI is changing the type of talent being hired as it increases the requirement for tech-enabled field teams

changing the type of talent being hired, the experts noted, as it increases the requirement for more productive, tech-enabled field teams.

Highly repetitive and compliance-driven roles, like manual audits, basic data collection and standard reporting, are increasingly vulnerable. AI tools like image recognition, geo-tagging and automated reporting are reducing the need for manual intervention in these areas.

However, roles that involve direct selling, persuasion and relationship man-

agement remain resilient. In-store promoters, assisted selling executives and field sales representatives continue to be critical, especially in categories where customer interaction drives conversion.

TERRITORY PLANNING

Roles that require judgment, such as territory planning, performance management and escalation handling, are becoming more important.

“In the context of field marketing and sales outsourcing, AI is augmenting

human effort rather than replacing it. While certain elements like reporting, tracking and basic audits are being automated, the core of BPO-led field execution, especially in India, still relies heavily on human interaction at the last mile,” Abhinav Joneja, Vice-President, GI BPO, said.

He observed that hiring is shifting towards digitally fluent promoters who can use apps for assisted selling, real-time reporting and customer profiling, alongside rising demand for roles that interpret field data, such as performance dashboards and outlet-level insights, a trend set to accelerate over the next two years. At the same time, new roles are emerging, including field analytics specialists, tech-enabled programme managers, automation coordinators and retail intelligence teams that turn field data into actionable insights.

All eyes on *Dhurandhar 2*, with strong advance bookings

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

All eyes are on *Dhurandhar 2: The Revenge*, the sequel to the blockbuster hit *Dhurandhar*, which has been witnessing strong advance booking trends.

Dhurandhar, which was released in 2025, had emerged as the highest grossing Hindi film.

The spy action thriller, which will see its full theatrical release on Thursday, however, faced some glitches during the much anticipated select paid preview shows on Wednesday. Trade analysts and the multiplex industry, however, noted with a strong buzz, the movie is set to create new box office records.

On Wednesday evening, several users took to social media to complain about paid preview shows getting delayed or cancelled at several locations.



BIG OPENING. Ranveer Singh in a scene from the film

An official statement issued by Jio Studios and B62 Studios on Wednesday stated, “Most of our Hindi shows across India are running as scheduled from 5 pm onwards. All of our Tamil and Telugu shows will commence from 9 pm onwards. However, due to unforeseen technical difficulties, our Malayalam and Kannada shows will begin from tomorrow morning. If the

dubbed version you have tickets for is not currently playing at your cinema, you will have an option for refund or to watch the Hindi version with subtitles instead.”

SHOWS CANCELLED

Industry executives said that while a few shows got cancelled, many shows were delayed and shows in the southern region got can-

celled due to non-delivery of content. Meanwhile, as per estimates by trade site Sacnilk, the film's worldwide pre-sales for the opening weekend had already crossed the ₹200 crore mark, which includes over ₹125 crore gross in India. Trade analyst Taran Adarsh stated on X that the movie's sequel will be a “box office tsunami” with expectations that it will “demolish existing records”.

Gautam Dutta, Chief Executive Officer, Growth and Revenue, PVR INOX Ltd, told *businessline*, “By Wednesday afternoon, we have already seen advance booking of nearly 18.5 lakh tickets for the opening weekend. Given the strong admissions we had seen for *Dhurandhar*, we also expect to witness similar levels of strong occupancies and admissions for *Dhurandhar 2: The Revenge*.” Karan Taurani, EVP, Elara Securities noted in an analyst report that the film

had seen advance booking of 1.2 million tickets. He added that the movie is set for a massive pan-India release and may garner net box office collection of ₹100 crore on the first day. He added that the franchise may emerge as the highest-grossing film franchise in India in terms of net collections at the domestic box office.

FILLING FASTER

Bhuvanesh Mendiratta, MD, Miraj Entertainment Ltd added, “Advance bookings for *Dhurandhar: The Revenge* are clearly ahead of the first film at a similar stage. In many centres, we are already seeing 60-70 per cent occupancy for the opening weekend, with evening shows filling faster. The demand is also reflected in extended show windows, with select cinemas in metros running shows from early morning hours to post-midnight slots.”

Gulf Air adds flights to Chennai for stranded flyers

Anees Phadnis
Mumbai

Passengers stranded in Bahrain and Kuwait can now travel to India via Saudi Arabia as Gulf Air and Jazeera Airways have introduced special flights.

While Gulf Air will operate flights from Dammam to Chennai from March 21-28, Jazeera Airways of Kuwait will operate flights to six cities in India from Qaisumah airport in Saudi Arabia. Jazeera Airways has already opened bookings for its first two flights to Kochi on March 20 and 21.

LIMITED SERVICES

Airports in Bahrain and Kuwait have been closed since start of conflict on Feb-



Chennai international airport

ruary 28. With no direct connectivity available the airlines have started limited services from airports in Saudi Arabia. Indian Embassies in Bahrain and Kuwait co-ordinated with authorities and resident associations for these services.

Gulf Air has been operating a flights from Dammam to Mumbai, Bangkok and

London. On Tuesday the airline added Cairo, Casablanca and Chennai to its temporary network. Gulf Air said transport between Bahrain and Dammam will be arranged by the airline for passengers holding confirmed tickets. The airline said it will also assist with Saudi transit visas for all such passengers.

Passengers will travel overland from Kuwait to Qaisumah. From Qaisumah, they will board outbound flights to their respective destinations. Incoming flights will also follow the same route, the airline said.

IndiGo said it is resuming flights to Dubai following the latest update from its civil aviation authority. The airline will operate one flight between Mumbai and Dubai on Thursday.

Stocks



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Company	Prev	Close	Open	High	Low	Qty	SZWH	SZWL	PE	BSE CI
ONGC [5]	264.75	265.05	264.55	266.65	263.00	878086	29.15	205.00	10	264.85
ONGMOBILE	49.38	50.11	49.38	50.11	48.51	27614	75.00	40	50.24	
Onward Tech	729.20	248.30	230.00	254.75	229.95	9355	382.00	26.80	17	658.80
ORCL	126.12	126.12	126.12	126.12	126.12	250	12.00	14	30.80	
ORACLE FIN	630.00	6594.61	653.00	6666.00	631.50	32118	994.00	6232.20	16	249.85
Orchid Phr	528.95	538.40	530.50	543.55	526.75	1172	899.00	489.00		
ORIENT CERA [1]	126.12	126.12	126.12	126.12	126.12	42.25	12.00	14	30.80	
Orient Cera	34.94	38.19	34.21	38.99	34.21	96.50	56.4	28.67		139.30
Orient Elect	162.65	169.42	164.00	172.00	163.17	259.00	248.00	155.35		
Orient Hotel [1]	87.57	92.41	88.10	93.55	88.00	299.00	168.00	80.50	28	92.55
Orient Paper [1]	61.20	65.65	60.00	66.80	60.05	70.75	15.54	15.70		
Oriental Min	36.25	269.55	267.50	273.00	267.64	270.42	513.00	254.00		
Oriッサ Min [1]	353.70	3651.40	353.00	3702.00	353.00	1318	6132.00	3450.00		3650.10
Oriッサ Min	126.12	126.12	126.12	126.12	126.12	42.25	12.00	14	30.80	
Osa Hoyer	5.81	5.52	5.52	5.52	5.52	1094.42	33.08	5.52		
Oswalchem	23.25	23.25	23.11	26.44	23.11	64.02	59.00	23.11		
OswalPumps	302.90	318.65	308.00	323.00	303.00	1187.64	888.40	283.10		

P&G Health	492.00	493.90	493.70	496.40	490.20	10.72	673.00	425.00	
Pace Diptek	166.90	171.35	167.10	173.40	165.63	78.82	231.00	173.05	
Page Ind	305.10	302.130	306.00	318.40	304.00	19.66	5074.60	2980.00	4631.72
P&G India	80.80	86.93	79.20	89.79	79.20	455.58	226.78	74.12	
P&G India Bio [1]	317.20	340.59	319.00	343.15	319.00	133.73	181.00	306.00	341.35
P&G India	126.12	126.13	126.25	127.30	126.25	46.11	115.11	236.00	13
Paradeep Phos	112.30	116.15	112.50	118.20	111.54	4883.17	234.39	89.73	
Paradeep Phos	197.20	201.74	199.20	206.00	198.64	93.23	273.20	142.10	16
PARAMOUNT	33.75	35.05	33.97	35.58	33.76	681.68	62.30	30.73	18
Paras Defen	109.27	112.66	108.62	115.48	108.62	99.28	172.30	105.13	
Paras Hotels	19.97	20.13	19.95	20.50	19.95	578.18	20.92	138.10	
Paras Medivo	61.20	65.65	60.00	66.80	60.05	70.75	15.54	15.70	
Parsons Defen	109.27	112.66	108.62	115.48	108.62	99.28	172.30	105.13	
Parsons Medivo	61.20	65.65	60.00	66.80	60.05	70.75	15.54	15.70	
Parsons Math	6.78	6.81	6.90	7.00	6.77	544.25	27.46	6.10	
Passputi Acre	44.99	46.36	44.80	46.60	44.80	130.06	63.50	40.10	
Pattani Ind	486.45	490.15	488.00	493.05	484.82	129.28	2011.00	476.45	
P&G India	243.3	249.97	249.97	255.00	249.97	133.73	181.00	306.00	341.35
P&G India	165.00	173.58	166.00	179.18	165.12	79.26	203.00	155.00	
PayTM	1022.00	1076.10	1023.00	1085.90	1023.00	2879.96	138.81	682.10	
P&G India	1498.20	1538.70	1498.00	1546.70	1494.80	484.24	1978.00	131.35	
P&G India	80.80	86.93	82.90	89.79	82.90	455.58	226.78	74.12	
PCBL	248.20	256.30	255.00	260.35	249.45	144.77	44.15	245.10	
P&G India	278.25	275.20	277.00	283.15	273.10	163.57	66.00	259.40	
P&G India	243.3	249.97	249.97	255.00	249.97	133.73	181.00	306.00	341.35
P&G India	141.56	143.61	142.00	145.54	140.93	987.31	79.30	133.10	
P&G India	4529.40	4698.60	4525.00	4775.00	4525.00	75.70	6597.00	4163.80	47
P&G India	287.20	291.60	289.25	295.45	287.20	350.90	326.60	263.70	
P&G India	243.3	249.97	249.97	255.00	249.97	133.73	181.00	306.00	341.35
P&G India	523.85	536.85	529.75	542.55	525.00	2997.49	3008.00	471.15	123
P&G India	1472.10	1537.10	1458.00	1577.90	1486.00	97.94	1963.30	884.00	93
P&G India	1595.80	1637.30	1591.00	1633.90	1572.80	52.79	1965.00	1403.00	199
P&G India	80.80	86.93	82.90	89.79	82.90	455.58	226.78	74.12	
P&G India	2893.20	2927.60	2895.10	2958.20	2886.30	20.64	4329.00	2841.60	27
P&G India	547.80	546.20	553.00	564.80	545.00	139.83	40.50	515.00	
P&G India	1457.00	1478.10	1357.00	1391.50	1457.00	540.07	157.95	1325.15	61
P&G India	449.60	478.00	433.00	438.00	438.00	140.00	180.00	158.42	
P&G India	160.63	171.40	161.00	172.60	160.00	94.00	287.80	158.42	
P&G India	1769.30	1808.40	1761.00	1804.00	1760.00	95.95	1954.00	1260.00	
P&G India	1769.30	1808.40	1761.00	1804.00	1760.00	95.95	1954.00	1260.00	
P&G India	773.40	794.70	770.70	854.45	770.30	47.92	1121.00	677.20	28
P&G India	1429.60	1451.00	1441.80	1459.00	1417.00	17.25	1799.60	1220.10	
P&G India	203.05	211.00	203.18	214.47	203.93	24.53	342.00	199.05	
P&G India	33.82	34.65	34.49	34.90	33.81	47.30	58.24	32.50	
P&G India	505.55	506.85	555.00	564.70	553.00	144.88	70.10	473.80	
P&G India	68.69	70.27	69.00	71.66	69.00	364.20	119.40	68.16	5
P&G India	779.95	807.65	784.05	813.45	783.20	102.25	1141.85	730.00	9
P&G India	366.15	371.65	367.15	372.60	365.30	292.26	43.00	360.00	
P&G India	859.35	864.60	859.00	889.20	854.00	48.94	1399.05	692.55	
P&G India	716.56	734.30	720.00	740.00	716.50	683.93	87.02	4567.00	37
P&G India	826.60	885.00	830.00	907.00	828.85	35.28	1396.70	775.00	41
P&G India	406.00	412.05	408.00	416.00	406.00	226.31	47.00	281.35	
P&G India	112.00	112.00	112.00	112.00	112.00	29.99	87.00	220.05	
P&G India	418.05	432.25	420.95	434.45	418.05	210.51	242.45	330.05	8
P&G India	298.50	299.00	299.00	300.20	297.55	8691.70	32.15	25.00	8
P&G India	159.10	163.75	160.50	164.65	159.10	141.58	206.90	142.60	12
P&G India	304.65	306.40	305.05	309.50	304.60	115.76	79.19	273.05	36
P&G India	119.07	122.10	119.05	123.85	119.04	307.53	19.10	110.00	7
P&G India	186.50	186.50	186.50	186.50	186.50	105.55	473.90	183.61	12
P&G India	121.00	121.00	121.00	121.00	121.00	29.99	87.00	220.05	
P&G India	290.55	307.65	293.45	315.00	287.30	636.95	25.95	118.35	43
P&G India	811.20	869.60	818.80	876.00	813.00	1682.94	1163.90	660.00	
P&G India	126.50	126.50	126.50	126.50	126.50	29.99	87.00	220.05	
P&G India	126.50	126.50	126.50	126.50	126.50	29.99	87.00	220.05	
P&G India	52.45	54.85	52.40	56.30	52.40	301.69	69.45	381.50	42
P&G India	25.26	26.41	25.28	26.80	25.27	315.76	29.40	85.84	26
P&G India	125.26	126.41	125.10	127.52	125.10	122.87	17.15	110.05	
P&G India	2933.90	2996.00	2934.00	3001.00	2929.90	62.39	340.50	1482.00	
P&G India	1000.00	1001.00	1007.00	1009.00	996.00	62.37	1436.60	998.70	3810.02
P&G India	112.00	112.00	112.00	112.00	112.00	29.99	87.00	220.05	
P&G India	511.55	531.10	515.00	537.75	514.95	346.23	184.00	1750.00	
P&G India	2279.40	2358.30	2294.00	2377.90	2273.60	45.18	3098.00	570.05	
P&G India	17186.00	17346.00	17200.00	17410.00	17160.00	1251	19387.00	11902.00	74
P&G India	26.67	27.59	26.70	27.84	26.69	690.20	44.90	24.03	5
P&G India	72.51	74.02	72.55	74.99	71.95	103.28	148.05	63.11	8
P&G India	121.00	121.00	121.00	121.00	121.00	29.99	87.00	220.05	
P&G India	22.91	23.52	22.99	23.66	22.98	1391.88	59.00	22.60	14
P&G India	18.51	19.01	18.00	19.40	18.00	350.67	338.00	160.00	
P&G India	25.15	25.66	25.45	26.49	25.41	384.39	39.88	18.26	2
P&G India	1003.30	1019.20	1010.00	1028.00	1008.70	373.99	1249.70	83.00	